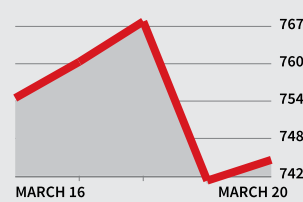


SENSEX 74532.96 (+325.72)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23114.50	+112.35
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.46	+0.09
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.71	+1.08
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	146628.00	-669
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	232364.00	+2491

WELFARE PUSH.

The Labour Ministry is examining domestic, global models to draw up a social security scheme for gig workers **p10**



AUTO FOCUS.

Skoda Kushaq update adds features, improves drive, but faces competition and expectations **p4**

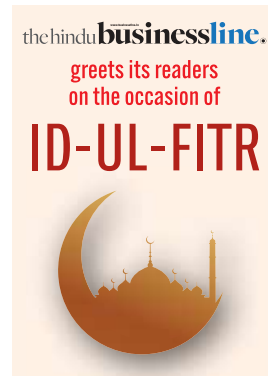
QUICKLY.

FISCAL TIGHTROPE

Telangana's FY27 budget pegged at ₹3.24 lakh cr



Hyderabad: Amid mounting public debt of ₹5.62 lakh crore weighing on the State's finances, Telangana Deputy Chief Minister and Finance Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka presented a ₹3.24 lakh crore budget. To manage the debt burden, the government announced the restructuring of ₹25,612 crore in high-interest loans. To meet the increased capex and fund welfare schemes, he indicated that the State would go for open market loans of ₹73,383 crore and ₹5,500 crore from the Centre as a loan. **p9**



HDFC Bank board to meet next week on new chairman

HEAD-HUNTING. May look at a career central banker; bank shares take a hit, again

Our Bureau
Mumbai

HDFC Bank's board of directors is scheduled to meet mid next week to take stock of the situation arising from the abrupt resignation of Part-Time Chairman Atanu Chakraborty and discuss a possible replacement for him.

While HDFC Group veteran Keki Mistry stepped in as Interim Part-time Chairman with effect from March 19, for a period of 3 months, the board is keen on fast-tracking the process of finding a replacement for Chakraborty, said sources clued into the developments at the private sector lender.

In an analyst call, Mistry had said: "As far as our seeking some explanation from Chakraborty, the board will of course meet very, very soon and take a call on how to take it forward."

EYE ON EX-RBI OFFICIAL

The possibility of calling on a career central banker such as M Rajeshwar Rao, a former Deputy Governor of the RBI, is high, they said. It may be pertinent to mention here that Shyamala Gopinath, a



PROBE SIGNAL. Though the central bank reassured investors on the private lender's health, it could conduct an independent probe on the goings on at the bank, said experts **REUTERS**

former Deputy Governor of the RBI, was Chairperson of HDFC Bank from 2015 till 2021.

INVESTOR JITTERS

Chakraborty stirred a hornet's nest by suddenly resigning, citing "certain happenings and practices within the bank."

The after-shock of his exit continued to reverberate and impact investor confidence on Friday as the fire-fighting by the bank's board and the RBI neither revealed many details nor denied the allegations.

The management's explanation and the RBI's confidence-building exercise were not convincing enough, said analysts.

Shares of the bank hit another new low at ₹772 before pulling back slightly to close at ₹780 on Friday.

Chakraborty's attempts to play down the issue later, stating that his resignation was "routine" and not indicative of any wrongdoing at the bank, did not cut ice, either.

Shriram Subramanian, Founder and Managing Director of proxy advisory firm Ingovern Research Services, said the committee of independent directors should constitute a separate fact-finding panel on the allegations made by Chakraborty and come out with a white paper to assuage investors' concerns, besides elaborating on any action that needs

to be taken to avoid a repeat of such incidents that erode investor wealth. Though the central bank reassured investors on the bank's health, it could also conduct an independent probe on the allegations, he added.

SKIN IN THE GAME

As banking industry veteran Uday Kotak advocates, Subramanian said, bank promoters need to have a "skin in the game" to ensure accountability, as managers with no ownership can make risky lending decisions using depositors' money.

Sameer Sawant, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset Sharekhan, said that despite the assurances given by the bank and the RBI, the overhang lies in the two pending decisions on the appointment of a permanent chairman and the call on MD and CEO Sashidhar Jagdishan's reappointment, both of which markets will price cautiously until resolved.

Given that HDFC Bank is a widely-held company without a controlling promoter, large investors, in particular, should engage with the board and demand transparency on "ethical concerns," he said.

Re sinks 108 paise to breach 93/\$

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The rupee recorded one of its biggest single-day falls in recent times, sinking 108 paise against the US dollar and plummeting past the 93 mark, weighed down by hardening crude oil prices due to the ongoing West Asia war, FPI outflows from the equity market and a strong dollar. The Indian currency closed at an all-time low of 93.71 per dollar against the previous close of 92.63.

Opening weaker at 92.89, the rupee tested an intra-day high/low of 92.88/93.75. The last time the rupee fell by more than 100 paise was on June 4, 2024, when it crashed by about 139 paise.

V Rama Chandra Reddy, Head - Treasury, Karur Vysya Bank, said the sharp depreciation of the rupee is a reflection of significant deterioration in global risk sentiment.

"The currency came under pressure primarily due to heavy FII outflows and a sharp surge in crude oil prices that climbed to around \$118/barrel, driven by the escalating crisis in West Asia.

"... If the conflict persists, the implications for the global economy and particularly for India can be severe, potentially exceeding the impact witnessed during the Global Financial Crisis and the Covid-19 pandemic," Reddy said.

Govt's ₹20,000 cr scheme to ease MFIs' funds crunch

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The government has rolled out a ₹20,000 crore Credit Guarantee Scheme for Microfinance Institutions 2.0, a move the industry body Microfinance Industry Network (MFIN) said would help revive credit flow to underserved segments and ease funding constraints in the sector.

The scheme comes amid a sharp decline in bank funding to microfinance institutions (MFIs), particularly small players. According to MFIN, bank lending to the sector dropped nearly 70 per cent between the fourth quarter of FY24 and the third quarter of FY26, severely impacting liquidity.

LOAN PRICING

Loans under the scheme will be priced at a capped rate linked to the EBLR or 1-year MCLR plus 2 per cent. In turn, MFIs must lend at least 1 percentage point below their average rate over the past six months. Loans will have a maximum tenure of three years, including a one-year moratorium.

Exposure is capped at 20 per cent of an MFI's AUM, with absolute limits of ₹100 crore for small, ₹200 crore for medium and ₹300 crore for large MFIs. The scheme



The scheme comes amid a sharp decline in bank funding to microfinance institutions

also mandates that at least 5 per cent of the loans go to small MFIs and 10 per cent to mid-size players. Credit guarantee cover ranges from 70 per cent for large MFIs to 75 per cent for medium and 80 per cent for small MFIs.

The launch also coincides with improving asset quality metrics. Portfolio at Risk (PAR) for 31-90 days declined to 1.6 per cent from 3.2 per cent a year ago, indicating better repayment.

However, constrained liquidity has weighed on growth, with the industry's portfolio standing at ₹3.15 lakh crore as of December 31, 2025, a 7.3 per cent sequential decline.

The funding crunch has had a direct impact on borrowers, with MFIN estimating that nearly 50 lakh customers lost access to formal credit due to reduced lending activity.

Consumer durable makers to hike prices as plastics, polymers and freight costs soar

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Consumer durable manufacturers are facing intense cost pressures driven by soaring prices for plastics and polymers, compounded by a weakening rupee and the geopolitical instability in West Asia. Leading appliance manufacturers have signalled a price hike for air-conditioners, washing machines and refrigerators this April. Depending on the brand and model, consumers can expect a price adjustment ranging from 3 to 10 per cent.

High crude oil prices and supply disruptions have driven up the cost of petrochemical derivatives, such as polypropylene, styrene monomer and ABS, all of which are critical inputs for



High crude oil prices and supply disruptions have driven up the cost of all critical inputs for appliances

appliances. The impact is being compounded by a weakening rupee, a spike in freight rates, and tightening cost structures across the value chain.

PRICING IMPACT

The extent of the pass-through differs by category, largely depending on the input intensity. NS Satish, President, Haier Appliances India,

said, "Factors such as a hike in prices of polymer, besides the rupee depreciation, have led to higher production costs for players. Players can absorb only some amount of the cost increase. So, there is no choice for consumer durables companies but to hike prices in April." He indicated hikes of 8-10 per cent for air-conditioners and washing machines and 4-5 per cent for refrigerators.

Kamal Nandi, Business Head and EVP, Appliances Business, Godrej Enterprises Group, pointed to the confluence of global and logistical pressures driving this shift.

"Geopolitical tensions have driven up the costs of polymers and plastics, among others. Freight rates have also risen sharply. This has led to significant cost pressures for consumer durables

makers and not all of it can be absorbed. So we will have to take price hikes," he said, outlining increases of 3-5 per cent for air-conditioners, 7-10 per cent for washing machines and 5-7 per cent for refrigerators.

COST SURGE

Television manufacturers are also feeling the pinch as input costs climb across multiple fronts, from polymers to metals to logistics.

Arjun Bajaj, Director of Videotex, said, "Polymer-based materials used in cabinet parts, cables and insulation materials have seen price increases of 40-50 per cent, while copper prices remain at record highs." He added that currency volatility and a 300-400 per cent spike in ocean freight charges are further inflating costs.

IFSCA flags compliance breach by Gift City market participants

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

The International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) has issued 60 warnings to capital market intermediaries operating in Gift City in FY26 for lapses, including unattended offices, absence of key personnel, weak infrastructure and use of remote access software for trading.

IFSCA, after a series of market intelligence visits to assess operational "substance" among registered entities, found that several intermediaries were either non-functional during business hours or lacked key managerial personnel at their registered offices.

IFSCA flagged structural weaknesses, including inadequate infrastructure to support core business activities and instances of the same individual handling both compliance and trading roles.

Read more on p3

Slew of generic semaglutide set to launch 80% cheaper than Novo Nordisk's Ozempic

PT Jyothi Datta
Naga Sridhar
Mumbai/Hyderabad

Drug-makers Natco Pharma, Glenmark Pharmaceuticals and Eris Lifesciences are poised to launch their generic versions of semaglutide for Type-2 diabetes on Saturday, pricing them over 80 per cent lower than the innovator Danish healthcare company Novo Nordisk's Ozempic.



prices — a development that has doctors cautioning against possible indiscriminate use.

Diabetologist Rajiv Kovil, with Zandra Healthcare, told *businessline* that patient selection is critical to ensure they can tolerate the product, besides checking for eye-related issues, pancreatitis and family history of thyroid cancer.

GENERIC PRICES

The vial format provides doctors flexibility in dosing, he explained, adding that mi-

cro-dosing by patients would require education and hand-holding to prevent errors.

Natco priced its semaglutide in multi-dose vials at ₹1,290 per month for 2 mg/1.5ml and 4mg/3ml, and ₹1,750 for 8mg/3ml. The pen device, slated for launch in April, is to be priced ₹4,000, ₹4,200, and ₹4,500 per month for 2mg/1.5ml, 4mg/3ml and 8mg/3ml, respectively, it said.

Natco has a pact with Eris Lifesciences that has also announced similar pricing and timeline for its 2 mg/1.5ml and 4mg/3ml vials and pens, respectively.

Glenmark Pharmaceuticals' generic Semaglutide will be available in vials with dose-specific syringes, besides the pre-filled pen. The expected weekly cost of the vials ranges from ₹325 (about ₹1,300 a month) to ₹440, Glenmark said.

Novo Nordisk's Ozempic is priced between ₹8,800 and ₹11,175, in the pen format.

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2 YEAR **1,00,00**

Mumbai: Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd (TMPV) on Friday said it will raise prices across its internal combustion engine (ICE) portfolio by a weighted average of 0.5 per cent, effective April 1. The increase, the company said, would vary by model and variant as it seeks to partially offset rising input costs amid sustained inflationary pressures. Even as manufacturers grapple with higher commodity prices and logistics costs, Tata Motors joins a growing list of automakers recalibrating pricing to protect margins amidst a challenging cost environment. **OUR BUREAU**

CM
YK

QUICKLY.

‘Removing sanctions on Iran oil will ease supply’



Washington: Removing sanctions on stranded Iranian oil would get supplies to Asia within three or four days, said US Energy Secretary Chris Wright (*in picture*) on Friday. “Within days, within three or four days, that oil will start to arrive at ports,” said the Energy Secretary in a TV programme. Wright said the unsanctioned oil would then be refined and hit the market over the coming month-and-a-half. REUTERS

Core sector growth slows down to 2.3% in Feb

New Delhi: Production growth in eight core infrastructure sectors slowed down to 2.3 per cent in February, from 3.4 per cent in the same month last year, according to government data. Production of crude oil, natural gas and refinery products declined during the month. During April-February, the cumulative production growth in infrastructure sectors was 2.9 per cent, compared with 4.4 per cent in the same period in the last financial year. PTI

Iran and Israel continue to trade blows as war rages on

HARD STANCE. Khamenei names new year ‘resistance economy under national unity’

Reuters
Tel Aviv/Dubai/Washington

Iran attacked an oil refinery in Kuwait on Friday and Israel killed a spokesman of Iran’s Revolutionary Guards as the US-Israeli war on Iran showed no sign of ending.

Israel promised to avoid further attacks on Iran’s South Pars gas field the day after an Iranian retaliatory strike on Qatar caused damage that will leave the world short of natural gas for years to come.

The benchmark price of Brent crude oil stabilised at around \$110 after surging the day before on growing fears that the largest ever disruption to world energy supplies would trigger a global economic shock.

NO QUICK RECOVERY
But warnings mounted that even if the war ends soon, there will be no rapid recovery from the upheaval caused by airstrikes and Iran’s virtual closure of the Strait of Hormuz, the conduit for 20 per cent of the world’s oil and liquefied natural gas. Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei



OF WHAT REMAINS. A member of the Israeli police inspects part of an Iranian missile in a living room, after Iran launched a barrages of missiles towards Israel on Friday REUTERS

released a message on Friday marking the start of Persian New Year, which he named the year of a “resistance economy under national unity and national security.”

In the statement, released on his Telegram channel, Khamenei said that attacks against Turkey and Oman were not carried out by Iran or its allied forces.

President Donald Trump repeated a call for major US allies and others, none of which were consulted or advised on the war, to help secure the safety of shipping.

Germany, Britain, France, Italy, the Netherlands, Japan

and Canada pledged in a joint statement to join “appropriate efforts to ensure safe passage through the Strait.”

But German Chancellor Friedrich Merz made clear that this presupposed an end to combat. French President Emmanuel Macron said after a European Union summit in Brussels that defending international law and promoting de-escalation was “the best we can do”, adding: “I have not heard anyone here express a willingness to enter this conflict — quite the opposite.”

Kuwait’s state oil firm said

IFSCA issues 60 warnings as CMIs breach compliance norms

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

The International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) has issued 60 warnings to capital market intermediaries (CMIs) operating in Gift City this fiscal year for compliance lapses, including unattended offices during business hours, absence of key personnel, weak operational infrastructure and use of remote-access software for trading.

The unified regulator, which has been conducting a series of market intelligence inspections to assess operational substance among registered entities, found that several intermediaries were either non-functional during business hours or lacked key managerial personnel at their registered offices.

In several instances, neither the Principal Officer nor the Compliance Officer was present, raising concerns over governance and accountability standards.

INADEQUATE INFRA
IFSCA also pointed to structural weaknesses, including inadequate infrastructure to support core business activities, and instances of the same individual handling both compliance and trading roles, highlighting potential conflicts of interest.

The regulator further



noted the use of remote access tools for trading activities, practices that are inconsistent with the regulatory framework governing operations in the IFSC.

ACTION INITIATED
IFSCA officials told *businessline* that in FY26 (till date), warnings have been issued in 60 cases with 10 cases referred to enforcement. In another 51 cases, IFSCA issued advisories.

“In some CMIs, one common person was appointed both as Principal Officer and Compliance Officer.

“In a few cases, these instances were repeated despite the issuance of warnings/advisories by the Authority to the CMIs... In some cases, IFSCA officials also observed that the Compliance Officer was also handling the trading desk, which is a conflict of interest,” IFSCA stated.

“In some CMIs, the designated Principal Officers and Compliance Officers lacked

adequate awareness of the regulatory framework applicable to Capital Market Intermediaries. Additionally, it was observed that in some cases, only back-office staff were present during inspections,” it added.

Over 175 CMIs function out of Gift IFSC, which include broker-dealers (92) and clearing members (24). There are also a smaller number of credit rating agencies, custodians, debenture trustees, depository participants, distributors of capital market products and services, global access providers, investment advisors, investment bankers and research entities.

KEY PROVISIONS
These findings by IFSCA point to breaches of key provisions under the IFSCA Capital Market Intermediaries Regulations, 2025, particularly those relating to the physical presence of key management personnel and maintenance of operational infrastructure.

Despite warnings and advisories, certain entities were found to be repeat offenders.

Following the inspections, IFSCA initiated regulatory action against the non-compliant intermediaries and issued a broader advisory to all market participants to ensure strict adherence to regulatory requirements.

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Friday stressed that the new Income Tax Act must be grounded in an ethical framework and called upon tax officials to leverage technology extensively to identify and penalise evaders.

Addressing *PRARAMBH 2026: A Nationwide Awareness Campaign on the Income Tax Act, 2025*, the Minister spoke as the Income Tax Department officially notified the new I-T Rules. Both the revised Act and its accompanying Rules are set to take effect on April 1.

“The Income Tax Act, 2025, must be rooted in moral and ethical systems. We need to strengthen and protect our fiscal national sovereignty. These reforms are not merely data-driven; they are valid, legitimate systems built on a foundation of trust with the taxpayer,” Sitharaman stated, expressing confidence that the new legislation will establish India as a pre-eminent tax-friendly jurisdiction.

“Make paying taxes so seamless that honesty becomes the natural choice. However, for those wilfully evading or deliberately attempting to bypass the law, technology must be the tool that catches them. The message to the taxpayer should be clear: if you are honest, the system will make your

its Mina Al-Ahmadi refinery had suffered multiple drone attacks, setting some units alight.

Flows of crude and petroleum have dropped by about 12 million barrels per day – roughly 12 per cent of global demand — due to output cuts and export halts by Gulf producers.

Those barrels cannot easily be replaced by the transport, shipping and manufacturing industries that rely on them, and will make themselves felt for months or even years.

Israel’s military said it had attacked government facilities in Tehran. Iranian state TV said Ali Mohammad Naini, deputy head of public relations for the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, had been killed — the latest of dozens of leading government and military officials to be assassinated by Israel.

In Tel Aviv, air raid sirens howled as explosions from interceptors rang out. The military said Iran had fired a barrage of missiles at Israel.

Prospects of a truce have not been helped by the widespread perception that Israel and the US are pursuing different goals and strategies.

India plans LPG imports from Russia, Japan; shipments to arrive mid-April

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

As the conflict in West Asia intensifies, throttling 60 per cent of India’s consumption, the government is scouting for cargoes of the key cooking fuel from Russia and Japan, while also depending on the US for a major share of the lost cargoes.

Besides prioritising domestic liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) consumption over commercial use, sources said that India has also intensified diplomatic efforts to secure cargoes of the critical commodity — the main cooking fuel for more than 33 crore consumers.

TALKS UNDERWAY

“Cargoes are being sought from Russia, which are expected to start from next month. Talks are ongoing. Deliberations are also on to explore LPG from Japan, albeit the quantities will be low. Japan cargoes, if fixed, should reach India by mid-April. At this point, the objective is to arrange as much as possible from wherever possible,” said one of the sources.

On Thursday, Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson for the Ministry of External Affairs, said India aims to secure LPG from all available



sources, including Russia, to meet domestic fuel needs.

LPG MARKET TIGHT

“The silver lining is the ongoing diplomatic dialogue between Iran and India. This engagement helped enable Indian-flagged LPG carriers to transit the region, setting a positive precedent,” said Charles Kim, Associate Director for LPG at S&P Global Commodities at Sea.

Continued cooperation could support the passage of additional Indian-linked ships, keeping vital supply routes workable for India and offering some relief to the broader market, he added.

Besides, India is already in talks with the US to procure more propane cargoes. The world’s second largest importer procured nearly 4,80,000 tonnes of US-origin

LPG in the first two months of 2026, corresponding to around 11 very large gas carriers (VLGCs).

It has already secured a term tender for 2.2 million tonnes of US-origin LPG for 2026 – equivalent to about four VLGCs per month, said S&P.

SHIFT IN IMPORTS

According to S&P Commodities At Sea (CAS), India’s weekly LPG imports fell to 265,000 tonnes in the week to March 19, from 322,000 tonnes on March 5. West Asian inflows to India declined to just 89,000 tonnes in the week to March 19, representing only 34 per cent of total imports, the lowest share since January.

Alternative regional supplies increased to 176,000 tonnes in the week to March 19, up from zero the previous week when West Asia accounted for 100 per cent of imports, CAS data showed.

LPG prices have also risen amid persistent supply disruptions. Platts, part of the S&P Global Energy, assessed FOB AG propane and butane cargoes \$9 per tonne higher day over day at \$648 per tonne and \$642 per tonne, respectively, on March 18, following deals concluded on the Intercontinental Exchange during the end-of-day trading window.

New I-T Act to be rooted in ethics, says FM

Taxpayer friendly

Provision	Taxable value under Income Tax Rules, 1962	Taxable value under Income Tax Rules, 2026
Free or concessional education facilities for any member of employee household	Not taxable up to ₹1,000 per child	Not taxable up to ₹3,000 per child
Interest-free / concessional medical loan (specified diseases) made available to the employee or any member	No perquisite value if total loan ≤ ₹20,000	No perquisite value if loan ≤ ₹2,00,000
Free food and non-alcoholic beverages provided by employer	No perquisite value up to ₹50 per meal	No perquisite value up to ₹200 per meal
Value of gift, voucher or token from the employer	No perquisite value up to ₹5,000	No perquisite value up to ₹15,000
Tax-free medical travel benefit (abroad)	Not taxable if employee's GTI ≤ ₹2,00,000	Not taxable if employee's GTI ≤ ₹8,00,000
House rent allowance – 50% salary criterion cities	50% salary only for Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata; 40% for others	Ahmedabad, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune added to 50% category; others remain 40%
Children education allowance	Exempt up to ₹100 per month per child (max 2 children)	Exempt up to ₹3,000 per month per child (max 2 children)
Children hostel allowance	Exempt up to ₹300 per month per child (max 2 children)	Exempt up to ₹9,000 per month per child (max 2 children)
LTC exemption (for non-rail/ no recognised public transport connectivity travel)	Exemption up to equivalent AC First-Class rail fare	Fixed exemption limit of ₹30 per km (shortest route)

life easy; if you evade, the system will find you,” she added.

ARCHAIC LANGUAGE

The new Act streamlines the tax code by removing redundant provisions and archaic language. It significantly reduces the number of sections from 819 in the 1961 Act to 536, and trims the chapters from 47 down to 23. The total word count has been slashed from 5.12 lakh to 2.6 lakh.

Further, the new Bill in-

roduces 39 tables and 40 formulae for the first time, replacing dense prose with mathematical clarity.

THE NEW RULES

Under the updated Income-Tax Rules, 2026, the government has revised perquisite guidelines to explicitly include electric vehicles (EVs) within the concessional valuation slab for employer-provided motor cars. Additionally, provisions governing house rent allowance (HRA) have been modified.

“While the Income Tax Rules, 2026, under Rule 279, expand the 50 per cent HRA metro category to include Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune and Ahmedabad — bringing them on par with the traditional four metros (Mumbai, Kolkata, Delhi and Chennai) — the government has chosen not to include other high-rent, high-density employment hubs such as Noida, Gurugram and Navi Mumbai. These cities will continue to fall under the 40 per cent HRA bracket. The

expectation was that the rapid urbanisation and high rental costs in NCR extensions and satellite cities would justify their inclusion,” said Amit Maheswari, Managing Partner at AKM Global.

PIVOTAL CHANGE

Another pivotal change is the introduction of a detailed capital gains reporting framework. Taxpayers are now required to furnish transaction-level particulars, including dates of acquisition and sale, full value of consideration, costs of acquisition or improvement, and separate computations for long-term and short-term capital gains. This replaces the previous system of disclosing only aggregate figures.

According to Sudhakar Sethuraman, Partner at Deloitte India, taxpayers must adopt new forms, formats, and terminology starting April 1, while adhering to revised disclosure requirements and perquisite valuation rules.

“From a policy perspective, the emphasis has clearly shifted towards simplification, standardisation and enhanced transparency. The consolidation of forms, the introduction of the tax year concept and the rationalisation of provisions are expected to make the law more navigable, particularly for individual taxpayers and businesses,” he noted.

India doubles down on migration to PNG amid LPG shortfall

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

As the intensifying West Asian conflict clouds India’s supply of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), the government has unleashed a slew of measures, including re-prioritisation of resources, priority migration to piped natural gas (PNG) and crackdown on black marketing and hoarding.

“Supply of LPG is still a concern in view of the prevailing geopolitical situation and is being monitored,” said Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas (MoPNG) Joint Secretary Sujata Sharma on Friday during the inter-ministerial briefing on West Asia.

However, there are no dry-outs reported at distributorships so far, she added.

The country consumed more than 33 million tonnes (mt) LPG in FY25, of which 20.67 mt was imported. About 90 per cent of this imported quantity, or roughly



60 per cent of India’s total consumption, came from the Gulf transiting the Strait of Hormuz.

Sharma informed that around 11,360 tonnes of commercial LPG has been uplifted by the States in the past week with 50 per cent of the supply allocated for educational institutions and hospitals.

Besides, 18 States and UTs have issued orders for allocation of non-domestic LPG,

with supply being made available across all States and UTs. “Panic bookings have declined significantly from 89 lakh on March 13 to around 55 lakh yesterday (Thursday), while domestic LPG deliveries continue as normal,” she added.

The government on Friday raised the price of premium petrol (95-octane) from ₹99.89 per litre to ₹101.89 in Delhi. It also raised the price of commercial diesel by ₹22 a litre, from ₹87.67 per litre to ₹109.59 in the national capital.

PNG PUSH

The government continues to prioritise uninterrupted LPG supply and PNG expansion, particularly for households and priority sectors such as hospitals and educational institutions.

Measures include enhanced refinery production, revised booking intervals of 25 days in urban areas and up to 45 days in rural areas and prioritised allocation.

Alternate fuels such as kerosene and coal have been made available, with support from the Ministry of Coal for increased supply to States. States have also been advised to facilitate PNG connections, supported by incentives linked to additional LPG allocation.

Sharma said that city gas distribution (CGD) entities have been advised to prioritise PNG connections for commercial establishments such as hotels, restaurants and canteens.

Besides, the Oil Secretary has chaired a review meeting with CGD entities to expedite PNG expansion and emphasised transition from LPG to PNG.

“CGD companies, including IGL, MGL, GAIL Gas and BPCL, are offering incentives. CGD entities have been directed by the regulator PNG-GRB to shorten the timeline between the submission of applications and the commencement of gas supply to consumer households and

pursue mass awareness initiatives,” she added.

Over 13,700 new PNG connections have been issued in recent days and more than 7,300 consumers have shifted from LPG to PNG, helping reduce pressure on LPG demand.

BLACK MARKETING

Enforcement actions continue across States to curb hoarding and black marketing, with over 4,500 raids conducted and around 4,000 cylinders seized in the past 24 hours, said Sharma.

Significant actions have been reported in States, including Uttar Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Jammu & Kashmir, Punjab, Madhya Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan and Delhi.

The PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs) have conducted over 1,800 surprise inspections at retail outlets and LPG distributorships to ensure smooth supply and prevent irregularities.

Refractory production faces risk as shortage of LPG hits operations

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The refractory industry, a silent enabler of industrial growth, has been facing a serious challenge as disruptions to LPG supply are beginning to strain manufacturing operations.

The ongoing disruption has already started affecting refractory manufacturers across India. If the situation persists, it could significantly curtail production, particularly for units that depend heavily on LPG.

CORE SECTORS

The refractory industry supports a wide range of core sectors, including steel, cement, copper, aluminium and glass, with steel being the largest consumer.

Steel plants and other high-temperature industries rely on a steady supply of refractories for daily operations, maintenance and re-

lining. In a letter to the Union Ministries of Steel, Petroleum and Natural Gas, the Indian Refractory Makers’ Association urged the Central government to prioritise LPG supply for refractory manufacturers alongside domestic consumers.

HIGH-CALORIFIC FUEL

The urgency arises from the sector’s dependence on LPG as a clean, high-calorific fuel. Refractory manufacturing involves firing materials at temperatures often exceeding 1,200°C under tightly controlled conditions. Even small variations in heat or fuel consistency can affect product quality, durability and performance.

When supply becomes unreliable, manufacturers are forced to adjust firing cycles, delay production, or in some cases, pause operations altogether.

Switching to alternative

fuels is not a quick fix. Refractory kilns are designed for specific fuel types, and any transition requires time, investment and technical recalibration.

Parmod Sagar, Chairman, MD and CEO, RHI Magnesita India, said the ongoing disruption in fuel supply is not just an operational concern, it is a systemic risk for industries that depend on high-temperature manufacturing.

Without consistent access to fuels like LPG and natural gas, maintaining process integrity and output becomes extremely challenging, he said.

Sunanda Sengupta, Chairman, IRMA, and Executive Director, TRL Krosaki Refractories, said there is a wide range of refractories, each with its own specific firing requirements, making it difficult to change the fuel source quickly due to technological constraints.

QUICKLY.



Audi debuts the SQ8 in India at ₹1.78 crore

The German luxury carmaker has expanded its performance SUV line-up in India with the launch of the SQ8. Positioned between the Q8 and RS Q8, it brings a sportier edge to the flagship coupe-SUV range. Power comes from a 4.0-litre twin-turbo V8, paired with quattro all-wheel drive, producing 507 bhp and 78.5 kg-m. The cabin packs premium tech, advanced driver aids and distinctive S-specific styling.



TVS announces BaaS for its EVs, rolls out the Orbiter V1

TVS Motor Company has introduced a battery-as-a-service (BaaS) model across its electric two-wheeler range, aimed at lowering upfront ownership costs. Alongside, it launched the Orbiter V1 at ₹ 49,999 (with BaaS) as its most accessible EV. The BaaS model allows customers to subscribe to the battery separately, reducing purchase price. The plans start from ₹862 per month and spans up to 60 months.



2026 Renault Duster launched at ₹10.28 lakh

The French carmaker has reintroduced the popular mid-size SUV in India, marking its return to this segment. The new model gets multiple powertrains, including a 1.0-litre turbo-petrol (100 bhp/16.3 kg-m), a 1.3-litre turbo-petrol (163 bhp/28.5 kg-m) and a strong hybrid option that will debut around Diwali 2026. Based on the CMF-B platform, it offers 212 mm of ground clearance, a large touchscreen infotainment system, digital cluster and a suite of advanced driver assistance systems.

@TheMotorGram

Game of Thrones

FACE-OFF. Skoda gives the Kushaq a new face and, more importantly, a host of thoughtful upgrades that strengthen its arsenal



Ruman Devmane

Competition is meant to be a good thing; however, it often tramples the breed. Now, the class of SUVs that the Kushaq calls its playing field is among the toughest to crack, but it's also one that rewards handsomely. Like in every cut-throat class, there's an incumbent here, too, and it often overwhelms its peers with its success. Incumbents are also infamous for setting expectations — often in a debatable direction — and the rest are left with no choice but to simply follow. This mid-life update to the Kushaq is therefore, a lot about it keeping with the times while still trying to maintain its distinct and rather likeable identity.

The Kushaq arrived on a refreshing note about a few years ago, introducing a heightened degree of finesse to the class. Its blend of driving pleasure and a plush, up-market cabin experience (which it shared with its sibling, the VW Taigun), in addition to top-notch safety and build quality standards, single-handedly steered Skoda as a well-embedded player in this segment and, as a consequence, in India. Largely unchanged since its inception and with its rivals (Creta, Seltos, Grand Vitara and Duster, among others) doing their bit to turn up the heat, the Kushaq was in need of an insightful reassessment, something Skoda has duly performed and to good effect.

FIRST-MOVER

First up are a bunch of segment-firsts. A new 8-speed torque converter automatic gearbox has been introduced to the 1.0 TSI variant (it's either that or a 6-speed manual), and the rear seats now sport a massage function. There's also a Google Cloud-powered AI as-



UPGRADES GALORE. Rear seats with a massage function, revised cabin equipment and a new 8-speed gearbox are among the additions as part of this update SKODA AUTO INDIA



sistant which, on this test, I steered away from trying out. Next are a bunch of new features, namely a sunroof (standard across the range; Prestige and Monte Carlo variants get a dual-pane panoramic unit), an illuminated light band that runs across the breadth of the grille, illuminated 'Skoda' lettering incorporated into the connected tail-lamps, Park Pilot and a 26.03-cm virtual cockpit. The infotainment screen continues to offer a great user experience through great touch sensitivity and an intuitive layout.

The headline act here is, of course, the new Aisin 8-speed automatic gearbox. While it leaves elbow room for the 7-speed DSG (offered in the 1.5 TSI) to shine brighter, on its own it's a likeable gearbox offering smooth shifts and great driveability. At 80 kph, for instance, the revs drop to approximately 1600 rpm in 8th, as opposed to around 2200 rpm in 6th. This translates to improved highway efficiency from the 1.0-litre engine, which misses the cylinder deactivation tech seen in the 1.5. With a greater cruising ability, better efficiency and a stronger feature suite, the 1.0 clearly has evolved into an even more compelling buy.

It does struggle with low-speed ride quality, however. Around the



unruly bylanes of Jaipur, the 1.0-litre Kushaq felt pronouncedly lacking in suspension comfort, with thuds and mild rattles marring the experience. Over smooth roads, it's quick to transform into a stable and finessed car, but frankly you'd expect better from an SUV with a Skoda badge.

AT EASE

It's the 1.5 TSI variant that feels like the more 'Skoda' of the Kushaqs. Right from idle, it feels like the engine the Kushaq was built around and that's not just down to its higher power output (147.5 bhp as compared to the 1.0's 114 bhp). The larger engine's added weight, Skoda's product development team confirmed, seems to get the suspension to work better and the difference in low-speed ride quality is

Sound Majority

VOX POP. Kawasaki's popular 'big bike for the masses', the Z900, gets a substantial overhaul, stepping up its VFM quotient

If you chuckled at the pun concealed in the headline of this story, you have plenty of context on Kawasaki's Z900 being a bit of a mass sensation. Why is it one, though? While it's true that India has seen big-displacement motorcycles on sale for nearly the last two decades, we haven't yet outgrown the appeal of the howl an inline-four engine produces. I, for one, thought I had. But wrongly so.

Today, with twins of all kinds scattered across the motorcycle landscape and the V4 not being as much of a rarity, the inline-four engine sure has lost a bit of clout, at least among the motorcycling elite. For most of us, the sound an inline-four engine produces is among the most evocative ever. Why am I obsessing over this sound theory, though? Because it's perhaps a strong reason why the Z900 flies off the shelves. Aside from a few 'experimental' motorcycles from brands built on shaky ground, it's the Z900 (or the Z800 that preceded it) that democratised accessible inline-four performance in India.

It's more than just an aural indulgence, though. Especially in its latest form where it seems to

have gotten a bit more serious but also, fortunately, even more fun than earlier.

As the photographs will tell you, it looks a lot more appealing now, very much retaining its naked streetfighter styling but also appearing a touch more lithe than it has in the past. In reality, it still weighs 212 kg, just like the outgoing model. The new 'face,' sleeker-looking panels and, of course, the visually heavy mass the engine accounts for all come

together to give the Z900 a higher desirability factor.

When you swing a leg over, you'll be happy to find an assortment of premium switchgear, a new 5-inch TFT console that's packed with racy-looking readouts, a bunch of ride modes and cruise control and also not much motorcycle ahead of you as you settle into a riding position. At this point, you'll also find

ment of premium switchgear, a new 5-inch TFT console that's packed with racy-looking readouts, a bunch of ride modes and cruise control and also not much motorcycle ahead of you as you settle into a riding position. At this point, you'll also find

yourself rushing to thumb the starter and bring that angry (but super refined) motor to life. And then, you'll be enveloped by that characteristic howl you came for.

SOUND OF SPEED

I released the light clutch and, a moment later, found myself at a fairly heady speed, still accelerating relentlessly. The Z900 accel-

erates with intensity but equally with a sense of ease. All right, while that may be a quality that's common to a lot of performance motorcycles you can buy today, to be able to say that about a 123.6-bhp machine that offers no wind-protection is still no small matter. What adds to the excitement is a really good gearbox equipped with a two-way quick-

shifter, which adds seamlessness to the stunning acceleration the 948 cc engine generates.

Rideability is another strong-point of the Z, with its neatly calibrated throttle and its appetite for hanging around at low speeds even in 6th gear making it quite friendly in the city. Heat levels are typically high, though, and you'll desperately seek an escape route if you find yourself in a traffic jam. Kawasaki has also stepped up the brakes this time around and, paired with the new Dunlop Sportmax Q5A tyres, you can be confident about its dynamics package.

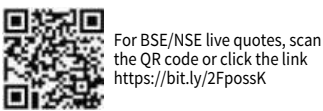
With quality and equipment levels having shot up, along with an appreciable step-up in performance and dynamics alike, the Z900 has clearly transitioned from something of an attention-hound to a motorcycle you'll thoroughly enjoy riding. At ₹9.99 lakh (ex-showroom), the Z900 comfortably undercuts the Ducati Monster, its closest but highly pedigreed rival from Italy. But its affordability isn't the only reason you should consider one. Just remember to buy your neighbours earplugs, please!

@TheMotorGram



STREET PREDATOR. The Z900 goes beyond just a restyling exercise; it now boasts radial brake discs, a 5-inch TFT screen, new tyres and, finally, a quickshifter! YASH GAWDE

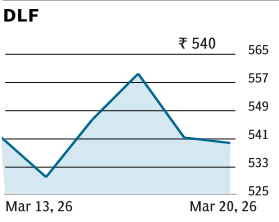




For BSE/NSE live quotes, scan the QR code or click the link <https://bit.ly/2fpossk>

QUICKLY.

Goldman Sachs, ICICI PruMF buy DLF shares



New Delhi: Goldman Sachs and ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund on Friday collectively bought over 43.40 lakh shares of real estate major DLF for nearly ₹231 crore through open market transactions. Goldman Sachs, through its affiliate Goldman Sachs Investments Mauritius I Ltd, and ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund purchased 21,70,473 shares each, amounting to a combined 0.17 per cent stake in Gurugram-based DLF, according to BSE block deal data. Shares were acquired at an average price of ₹531.7. Best Investment Corporation, and Baillie Gifford funds were the sellers. [PTI](#)

Polite Powertech files IPO paper with SEBI

New Delhi: Integrated power infrastructure EPC company Polite Powertech has filed its Draft Red Herring Prospectus with SEBI to raise funds through an Initial Public Offering (IPO). The IPO comprises a fresh issue of one crore equity shares and an offer for sale of 25 lakh equity shares. Proceeds from the issue will be utilised for funding working capital requirements and general corporate purposes. Polite Powertech is an integrated power infrastructure engineering, procurement and construction (EPC) company, engaged in the design, supply, installation, testing and commissioning of power transmission, distribution and renewable energy projects. [PTI](#)

BROKER'S CALL.

B&K Securities

HINDUSTAN ZINC (BUY)

Target: ₹668
CMP: ₹514.80
Since our initiation coverage, the stock price of Hindustan Zinc witnessed a sharp rally, delivering about 50 per cent returns, primarily driven by a significant increase in silver prices, which has a disproportionate impact on profitability, as silver is a by-product of lead production and a large portion of its revenues flow directly to the bottom line. This was further supported by firm zinc prices, which improved overall realisations. However, the stock has corrected meaningfully by about 30 per cent from its peak, largely due to a moderation in silver prices and valuation concerns after the sharp re-rating. Additionally, sentiment has been impacted by concerns around gas availability affecting downstream zinc demand, particularly in the galvanising segment. We think majority of the impact in terms of gas shortage will be on the colour-coated market in the galvanised steel segment. The company's 25 per cent export exposure provides a natural hedge against domestic demand fluctuations while also positioning it to benefit from rupee depreciation, which enhances realisations. We expect that the sales volume for silver should grow 10 per cent sequentially; this combined with the attractive valuations, due to the recent corrections, we have upgraded this stock to Buy, maintaining the target price of ₹668, valuing the company at an EV/EBITDA of 9x and 11x for Zinc & Lead and Silver segment respectively, on FY28E.

JM Financial

AEQUS (BUY)

Target: ₹145
CMP: ₹123.30
Aequs (Latin for equal) was incorporated in 2000 by promoter Aravind Melligeri, an engineering technocrat, who is the key driving force behind the company. Aequs has, in over a decade, transitioned into a tier-1 supplier for many aerospace majors (Airbus, Boeing, Safran). Its wins in key component programmes of majors has increased parts supplied by it to nearly 5,200+. Given that Airbus aims to increase sourcing from India to \$2.1 billion (FY30) versus \$1.4 billion (FY25) we see significant scope for growth. Aequs, with its unique end-to-end manufacturing/forging capabilities and its status as a D2P (Detailed to Parts) supplier for Airbus, stands to gain a higher programme share. Aequs is a combination of a well-established aerospace segment and the optionality of a potentially rapidly expanding consumer segment (off a low base). We value it at FY30E EBITDA, as that is when we expect key benefits of the intensive-capex phase to start showing up, and discount back to FY28 to derive our TP of ₹145. Given the current listing, the risk-reward is favourable and we initiate at Buy. In our valuation framework, 75 per cent of the value accrues from the established aerospace business underpinned by decades-old customer connections, while 25 per cent of the EV is from consumer, which is at a smaller, suboptimal scale currently (FY26) but has significant scale-up potential.

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Exchanges, clearing corps issue norms for closing auction session

ACTION PACKED. SEBI to introduce CAS framework initially for F&O stocks from Aug 3

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai



ON THE CARDS. The SOP details how settlement prices will be computed under different trading scenarios

Stock exchanges and clearing corporations have issued a joint standard operating procedure (SOP) for settlement price computation, following the rollout of the closing auction session (CAS) in the equity segment. SEBI plans to introduce CAS framework (initially for F&O stocks) from August 3.

The SOP details how settlement prices will be computed under different trading scenarios, with a shift towards auction-driven price discovery at the close. “For stocks where CAS is applicable... Stock Exchange shall provide the traded quantity in the CAS and the equilibrium price,” the SOP said.

Where equilibrium price and traded quantity are available from both exchanges, the settlement price will be based on the volume-weighted average price (VWAP) of the prices discovered. “If Equilibrium price & Quantity is provided by more than one Stock Exchange, then VWAP of such prices shall be considered as

settlement price,” it said. If data is available from only one exchange, that price will be adopted.

REFERENCE PRICE

In scenarios where no trades occur during the closing auction session but the stock has traded during the day, the reference price will be used as the close. If the stock re-

mains illiquid through both the day and the auction session, the previous day's settlement price will be carried.

For stocks where CAS is not applicable, the earlier framework remains in place. Settlement prices will be based on the VWAP of the last 30 minutes of trading where activity exists, or the last traded price (LTP) where it does not.

The SOP sets out norms for the equity derivatives segment. For contracts traded in the final 30 minutes, VWAP-based pricing will continue to determine the daily settlement price. On expiry, stock derivatives will take the final settlement price from the equity segment, while index derivatives will use the closing index value published by the exchanges.

Nifty stages modest rebound after Thursday's rout

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The benchmarks closed marginally higher on Friday, staging a relief rally after Thursday's steep sell-off, though markets pared a bulk of intra-day gains as a weakening rupee and lingering geopolitical uncertainty kept investor appetite in check.

The Nifty 50 ended at 23,114.50, up 112.35 points, while the Sensex closed at 74,532.96, gaining 325.72 points.

For the week, the Nifty ended marginally lower by 0.16 per cent. The recovery was largely technical, with easing crude oil prices —

after the US and Israel signalled that energy infrastructure in Iran would not be targeted — providing near-term relief.

“Lingering geopolitical tensions, continued weakness in the rupee and persistent FII outflows remain key overhangs,” said Ajit Mishra, SVP Research, Religare Broking.

Tech Mahindra led Nifty gainers at 3.4 per cent, followed by JSW Steel (at 3.3 per cent) and Tata Steel (at 3.1 per cent). However, Hindalco declined 2.8 per cent, and HDFC Bank fell 2.1 per cent.

Nifty Midcap 100 gained 0.67 per cent, and Nifty Smallcap 100 ended flat.

Accenture result, guidance lift sentiment for IT stocks

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Indian IT stocks rose following Accenture's Q2 results and guidance upgrade, which pointed to a largely unchanged demand environment, with growth increasingly driven by AI-led transformation, ecosystem partnerships and a broader services scope.

In Q2 of FY26, Accenture reported new bookings of \$22.1 billion, up 6 per cent in USD and 1 per cent in local currency. Revenue came in at \$18 billion, at an 8 per cent increase in USD terms and 4 per cent growth in local currency. The company has revised its full-year revenue

growth outlook to 3-5 per cent in local currency.

Following the announcement, the Nifty IT index closed at 29,199.60 on Friday, up 2.17 per cent. Shares of Indian IT firms gained across the board, with LTM up 3.73 per cent, Infosys 2.88 per cent, TCS 1.77 per cent and Wipro 1.32 per cent.

An Emkay Global Financial Services report noted that Nifty IT has corrected by around 25 per cent in CY26TD and underperformed the broader markets by about 13 per cent due to potential risks to growth, including the advancement of AI and increased macro uncertainties, which led to lower terminal growth assumptions.

SBI Mutual targets ₹13,000 cr IPO

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai



India's largest asset management company (AMC) SBI Mutual Fund has filed its Draft Red Herring Prospectus to launch about ₹13,000 crore IPO.

The fund house is a joint venture between State Bank of India and France-based Amundi. While SBI will offload 128,334,397 equity shares, Amundi India Holding will sell 75,374,842 equity shares in the IPO.

Currently, SBI owns 61.98 per cent in SBI MF, while Amundi has a shareholding of 36.40 per cent stake.

SBI MF manages assets worth ₹16.32 lakh crore and holds a market share of 15.55 per cent in the mutual fund industry.

The fund house will become the seventh AMC to list on the stock exchange after Nippon Life India Asset Management, HDFC AMC, ICICI Prudential AMC,

Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC, Canara Robeco AMC and UTI Asset Management Company.

The second-largest asset manager ICICI Prudential AMC commends a market capitalisation of ₹1.39 lakh crore.

LEAD MANAGERS

Kotak Mahindra Capital, Axis Capital, Jefferies, SBI Capital, ICICI Securities, Motilal Oswal, HSBC Securities, JM Financial and BofA Securities will be managing the issue and KFin Technologies will be the registrar.

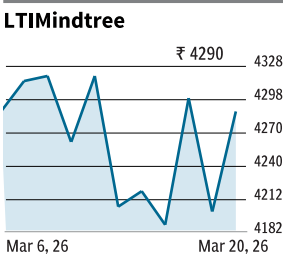
SBI Fund Management aims for a valuation of around ₹1.3 lakh crore from the IPO, which would trans-

late to a price-to-earnings ratio of about 51 times, said an analyst.

In the unlisted market, the shares currently trade at an estimated valuation of about ₹1.5 lakh crore.

Rajesh Singla, CEO & Fund Manager, Alpha AMC, said while the filing momentum suggests readiness, execution within the current financial year remains uncertain.

While short-term negative sentiments may impact listing gains, SBI MF operates in a structurally-strong segment of asset management which continues to benefit from India's long-term financialisation trend, growing SIP flows and retail participation, he said. The IPO is expected to come at a premium valuation, but the aggressive pricing could face resistance in current bearish market, as the issue is largely an offer-for-sale investors will closely evaluate valuation comfort rather than growth funding, he added.



Stable performance and a guidance upgrade may support valuations, but neither Accenture's Q2 results nor its commentary signals a meaningful near-term growth rebound.

CRITICAL SUPPORT

“From a technical standpoint, CNX IT is nearing a critical support zone around

26,000 on a monthly closing basis. The sector has been under pressure for a while, so this move is more of a potential stabilisation rather than a confirmed trend reversal.

“While global cues like Accenture may influence short-term sentiment, the bigger structural question for Indian IT remains around AI. The key variables are not just demand, but how AI-led efficiencies, rising chip costs and evolving client spending patterns impact revenue visibility,” Tushar Badjate, Director of Badjate Stock & shares, explained.

He added that parts of the IT space are beginning to look attractive from a risk-reward perspective. The real question is whether this be-

comes a cyclical bounce or the start of a more sustainable re-rating.

SERVICES SCOPE

For Indian IT Services, AI is widening the ‘services’ scope.

Accenture is positioning itself as an enterprise orchestrator — guiding deployment, integration, and transformation rather than owning models.

As clients move from pilots to production, new work streams are emerging across cybersecurity, core operations, and modernisation. However, limited quantitative disclosure on AI adoption and monetisation continues to constrain visibility on scalable, long-term growth.

From frenzy to freeze: When will retail investors reignite IPO demand?

RINGSIDE VIEW.



KS BADRI NARAYANAN

In recent times, initial public offerings (IPOs), once seen as a hotspot for retail investors chasing quick gains, have lost much of their appeal. Of the 14 mainboard IPOs, every second one failed to secure full retail subscription — only Shree Ram Twistex and Bharat Coking Coal Ltd (BCCL) drew strong interest.

IPOs of Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions, Sedemac Mechatronics, Omnitech Engineering, Rajputana Stainless and GSP Crop Science saw subscription of less than 0.5 times (or 50 per cent) of the quota.

SLIDE IN GMP

One key reason for the waning retail interest in IPOs is the sharp decline in grey market premiums (GMPs). Earlier, GMP was the primary reason luring retail investors into IPOs.

As the name implies, the grey market is an unregulated, unofficial market where shares are traded before their formal listing on stock exchanges.

Of the 12 companies listed

so far, seven are currently trading below their issue price, with losses going up to around 53 per cent in the case of Shree Ram Twistex. Ironically, Shree Ram Twistex had witnessed the highest retail participation at 76.63 times.

On the other hand, BCCL — another IPO with strong retail subscription (79.37 times) — continues to trade at a premium of 47.72 per cent.

As the market experienced turbulence due to the Iran-Israel-US war, retail investors became largely cautious across both primary and secondary markets.

SEBI STUDY

In 2024, due to the increasing participation of retail investors and the heightened over-subscription, SEBI launched an in-depth study to analyse investor behaviour in mainboard IPOs, based on April 2021 and December 2023 data.

The study revealed a “flipping” behaviour among individual investors. Individual investors sold 50 per cent of the shares allotted to them by value within a week of listing, and 70 per cent of shares by value within a year.

The study also found a “strong disposition effect”, with investors showing a

Lack of interest

Retail subscription (Number of times)		
GSP Crop Science	0.4	Shree Ram Twistex 76.63
Innovision	0.58	Gaudium IVF 7.6
Rajputana Stainless	0.27	Fractal Analytics 1.03
Sedemac Mechatronics	0.2	Aye Finance 0.77
Omnitech Engineering	0.33	Shadowfax Tech 2.31
PNGS Reva Diamond Jewellery	1.29	Amagi Media Labs 9.31
Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions	0.06	Bharat Coking Coal 49.33

Source: NSE India

greater propensity to sell IPO shares that posted positive listing gains, compared to those that listed at a loss.

Another interesting revelation was the influence of returns. “When IPO returns exceeded 20 per cent, individual investors sold 67.6 per cent of the shares by value within a week. In contrast, only 23.3 per cent of shares by value were sold when returns were negative.”

IPOs have increasingly turned into speculative plays aimed at making quick gains on listing day. The shortened listing cycle of just three days has further boosted investor interest, as funds are returned quickly, reducing the opportunity cost of idle capital. With this faster turnaround, the trend is likely to accelerate, as many investors continue to chase quick, easy profits.

However, with several big-

ticket IPOs — such as those from SBI Mutual Fund, National Stock Exchange of India, Reliance Jio, PhonePe, Flipkart, OYO and Zepto — expected to tap the capital markets, the current weakening sentiment in the primary market is a concern.

One hopes that investor confidence revives soon so that large and fundamentally strong companies can attract robust interest.

Before committing funds, retail investors should carefully assess an IPO's valuation, corporate governance standards, cash flows and the business' scalability. Taking a long-term view can benefit both investors and companies. At the same time, companies must price their offerings appropriately — leaving room for investor gains — while upholding high standards of corporate governance.

Norges Bank sells 0.6% stake in Zee for ₹44.4 crore

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Norges Bank Investment Management sold 60.98 lakh shares, or a 0.6 per cent stake, in Zee Entertainment Enterprises at an average price of ₹72.32 on Friday, for a total value of ₹44.4 crore.

Norges acted on behalf of the Government Pension Fund Global, which held 3.99 per cent of the company's shares in December.

Norges Bank acts as the overseer of the world's largest sovereign wealth fund, the Government Pension Fund Global.

PREFERENTIAL ISSUE

Earlier, Norges had supported Zee's proposal to issue convertible warrants on a preferential basis to its promoters.

Zee consolidated net profit in the December-ending quarter fell 5 per cent, primarily due to muted advertising revenue, while revenue grew 15 per cent, driven by positive growth in subscriptions and other sales and services. The broadcaster reported a net profit of ₹154.8 crore on revenue of ₹2,280 crore in the third quarter. EBITDA margin stood at 10.5 per cent.

Zee's share price fell by 1.51 per cent to ₹72.84 on the BSE.

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 112.35 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Reliance Ind	1414.40	43.84	19.58	9.06	
Infosys	1255.90	26.97	18.18	4.18	
Bharti Airtel	1846.10	11.58	28.41	4.88	
Tata Steel	196.77	11.35	26.39	1.34	
State Bank	1058.00	8.28	11.29	4.17	
JSW Steel	1169.60	7.98	36.83	1.04	
TCS	2390.60	7.75	18.03	2.39	
Sun Pharma	1777.10	7.60	38.93	1.72	
NTPC	380.95	7.18	14.88	1.71	
Coal India	468.15	6.94	97.02	1.01	
ITC	4106.60	6.22	76.50	1.61	
Tech Mahindra	1384.80	6.16	29.55	0.83	
Eternal Ltd.	232.29	5.60	970.42	1.58	
HCL Tech	1333.70	5.07	21.97	1.34	
Bajaj Auto	9051.00	4.44	28.45	0.95	
Tata Motors	299.95	4.12	18.15	2.74	
MG	3066.10	4.05	22.56	2.60	
Trent Ltd.	3559.60	3.78	78.12	0.75	
Eicher Motors	6909.00	3.50	35.37	0.90	
Dr Reddys Lab	1298.90	3.26	19.63	0.75	
UltraTech Cement	10934.00	3.12	42.05	1.23	
Apollo Hosp	7364.50	2.54	56.75	0.72	
Tata Motors PV	226.40	2.20	42.71	0.82	
Cipla	1256.40	2.12	22.39	0.67	
Max Healthcare	964.80	1.91	66.13	0.68	
Wipro	190.90	1.56	15.02	0.52	
Adani Ports	1365.40	1.52	25.17	0.96	
Nestle India	1193.60	1.15	70.57	0.81	
Hind Unilever	2062.70	1.05	48.67	1.75	
Adani Ports	2195.40	0.93	53.96	0.94	
PowerGrid Corp	297.60	0.89	17.83	1.28	
TataConsumerProduct	1050.20	0.80	70.62	0.65	
Grasim Ind	2616.30	0.70	18.80	0.95	
L&T	3434.80	0.08	24.90	3.83	
Maruti Suzuki	12601.00	0.06	26.53	1.57	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	239.30	0.11	34.74	0.61	
IntiglobeW	1419.10	-0.26	49.96	0.89	
Adani Enter	1927.10	-0.55	15.74	0.48	
Bajaj Finserv	1710.30	-0.58	14.23	0.93	
SBI Life	1896.90	-0.61	76.73	0.81	
Bajaj Finance	830.55	-0.96	28.20	2.09	
Abs Bank	142.85	-1.95	14.15	3.27	
Kotak Bank	366.75	-2.26	19.40	2.56	
HDFC Life	623.65	-2.32	71.19	0.64	
ONGC	265.40	-3.15	7.42	0.98	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	938.60	-3.44	19.30	1.25	
Bharat Elec	426.10	-3.69	52.23	1.45	
Hindalco	874.25	-7.24	12.22	1.20	
ICICI Bank	1245.40	-7.36	15.73	2.20	
HDFC Bank	780.45	-59.57	15.51	11.33	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▲ 288.50 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Jindal Steel	1186.50	54.26	60.04	2.08	
Divis Lab	6100.00	48.60	65.32	3.64	
Bank Of Baroda	279.95	40.91	7.37	2.44	
Canara Bank	136.44	35.60	6.72	2.16	
Vedanta	672.20	34.86	15.86	5.36	
Pidlitind	1341.30	30.19	58.99	1.96	
LTIMidtree	4298.80	27.91	26.98	1.87	
Punjab Natl Bank	111.53	21.10	7.17	1.81	
Indian Oilcorp	144.60	20.96	5.54	2.54	
Tata Power	402.40	19.65	25.67	3.17	
Torrent Pharma	4270.20	18.64	63.61	2.10	
Siemens	3129.60	13.42	70.29	1.30	
Abb India	6297.00	13.06	79.13	1.55	
Hindus Zinc	514.75	11.19	18.43	1.05	
Zyduslisciences	890.50	10.77	17.83	1.05	
Bpcl	287.80	10.47	5.07	2.62	
United Spirits	1300.10	9.92	54.98	1.80	
Siemens Energy India	2791.20	9.55	84.14	1.16	
Info Edge	978.20	8.86	37.64	1.79	
Shree Cement	23535.00	8.02	47.28	1.48	
AdaniGreenenergy	863.10	7.54	76.60	1.24	
Lic	776.75	7.13	9.26	0.81	
Bosch	30390.00	6.64	32.51	1.24	
Adani Power	151.54	6.27	25.86	2.81	
Tos Motor Corp	3462.20	5.64	53.87	3.82	
Indian Hotels Co.	615.55	5.01	40.48	2.54	
Adani Energy Solutions	1012.80	4.79	50.89	1.65	
Shree Cement	23535.00	4.37	40.68	2.82	
Jsw Energy	507.05	1.85	30.44	1.28	
Ambuja Cements	420.55	1.10	21.12	1.20	
Hyundai Motor India	1951.00	-0.21	27.38	1.31	
Bajaj Housing Finance	81.45	-0.84	27.39	0.36	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	94.69	-1.88	17.66	0.79	
Sansarmvorthosominteratl	111.59	-1.31	32.26	2.33	
Godrej Consumer Products	1017.60	-2.89	32.26	1.63	
Godrej Consumer Products	1017.60	-5.55	57.16	1.92	
Mazagon Dock	2324.10	-8.50	38.95	0.83	
Havells	1281.20	-9.91	54.20	1.52	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	681.60	-10.51	96.75	2.20	
ICI Lombard Cg	1777.20	-10.82	32.36	2.02	
Rural Elec	330.50	-10.87	50.5	1.94	
Gail (India)	1242.87	-11.33	109.2	1.81	
Hindustanpetronics	104.00	-11.44	28.43	0.37	
Varun Beverages	401.15	-13.34	34.43	2.50	
Steel Industries	12934.00	-16.44	76.66	1.48	
Avenuesuper	3770.80	-16.52	85.67	2.61	
Macrotech Developers	796.90	-17.77	23.79	1.05	
Cholamandamin&Fin	1440.50	-19.53	50.08	2.86	
Britannia Ind	5618.50	-18.46	56.00	3.11	
Bajaj Holdings	9512.00	-21.04	11.81	1.93	
Pts: Impact on index movement					

Resignation and after

Chakraborty could’ve done better

The sudden resignation of Atanu Chakraborty as part-time chairman of HDFC Bank has raised more questions than it has answered, and in a way that does not serve the interests of shareholders, depositors, or the financial system. In his resignation note, Chakraborty cited concerns around “ethical” and “governance” issues within the bank. They are loaded terms, capable of shaking investor confidence and triggering systemic anxiety.



Yet, he chose not to elaborate. If there were indeed such issues, a chairman’s responsibility is to ensure they are addressed through the proper regulatory channels. It is unclear whether he flagged these issues with the regulator and the bank’s board. The Reserve Bank of India stepped in to reassure stakeholders, stating that the bank remains fundamentally strong. This swift intervention suggests that the regulator saw no immediate “ethical” red flag that would justify a sudden loss of confidence. The bank’s management, too, sought to contain the fallout, suggesting that the resignation may have stemmed from differences with senior leadership rather than any substantive ethical breach. This divergence between what was said and what was later clarified is precisely the problem. If Chakraborty’s exit was indeed due to differences in approach or perspective with the executive team, invoking ethical and governance concerns was not just imprecise; it was injudicious. Words matter, particularly when they come from a distinguished personality entrusted with oversight of one of India’s largest financial institutions. The chairman’s communication is not a personal note; it is a market-moving statement.

Conversely, if there were governance issues serious enough to warrant resignation, the lack of disclosure is equally troubling. Stakeholders have a right to know. This episode underscores a deeper concern about leadership accountability in large corporations. The responsibility of those at the helm does not end with making decisions; it extends to how those decisions are communicated. In banking, where depositor confidence underpins the entire system, even unintended signals can have disproportionate consequences.

Chakraborty, given his experience as a former bureaucrat and regulator, would have been acutely aware of this dynamic. A more measured articulation, clearly distinguishing between governance concerns and managerial disagreements, could have prevented unnecessary erosion of shareholder value. The HDFC scrip fell sharply, due to perceptions shaped by incomplete communication. Ultimately, trust in banking is built not just on balance sheets, but on the conduct of key management personnel. Board members and chairmen must realise that their primary allegiance is to the institution and its stakeholders, not to themselves. If an ethical line has been crossed, it must be reported and rectified with evidence. For HDFC Bank, the challenge now lies in restoring the narrative of stability that this clumsy exit has so needlessly disrupted.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



POINT BLANK.



LOKESHWARRI SK

The Indian stock market has been hit by a series of unfortunate events since last year, making it one of the under-performers in this period.

The ongoing US-Israel-Iran conflict has turned out to be the final straw on the market’s back with the Nifty50 down around 7 per cent since February 26, when the hostilities began. While other markets are also moving lower due to surge in crude oil and gas prices, India seems to have been especially singled out due to the high dependence on imported crude oil and gas. Foreign portfolio investors have pulled out ₹77,214 crore in March so far, which is almost half of the total net outflow witnessed in 2025.

The question that is uppermost on everyone’s mind now is, how long will the war-induced correction in stock prices last. To get an answer, we looked at the reaction of Indian stock markets to severe geopolitical conflicts in the last 30 years.

WAR AND DALAL STREET

The Gulf war that began with Saddam Hussein invading Kuwait in August 1990 and ended with the Operation Desert Storm in February 1991 is the earliest war with significant impact on India in recent history. Disruption of supply made Brent crude oil prices double between August and October 1990. But crude oil prices cooled thereafter and were back to pre-war levels by March 1991.

The impact on Indian stock markets of the Gulf war was not much to write home about. Sensex fell around 30 per cent between September 1990 and January 1991. But the index turned around thereafter and did not look back.

This indifference was because there was lots happening at home during that time with the balance of payment crisis caused by the steep increase in crude oil prices in the late 1980s and the economic liberalisation that followed. With FPIs allowed into Indian markets and decontrol in many sectors, stock markets had plenty to celebrate after 1991.

The Iraq war which began with the US-led coalition invading Iraq in March 2003 also had only a short-term impact on Indian stock markets.

While the Nifty 50 declined about 8 per cent in the first month of hostilities, it revived after May 2003, when active combat was brought to a halt. The impact on crude oil prices was also limited to a rally of around 30 per cent, that too in the initial few weeks.

In the Russian invasion of Ukraine, which began in February 2022, prices of

Lessons from market moves in previous wars

An analysis of Indian stock market during previous wars shows that the volatility does not last long



REUTERS

commodities exported from Russia and Ukraine including base metals and agri commodities soared in the initial months, impacting stock prices. Brent crude oil prices hit a high of \$139 per barrel by March 2022. But prices began cooling thereafter to reach \$71 per barrel by June 2023. The Nifty50 fell gradually in the first few months to lose 12 per cent by June 2022. But the index recovered thereafter and managed to scale new peaks.

The revival in the economy after the Covid-19 pandemic allowed the economy as well as the markets to heal fast from the initial shock of the Russia-Ukraine conflict, which continues to rage on.

The Israel-Hamas conflict in October 2023 made crude oil spike initially from \$83 per barrel to \$92 in the first fortnight. But crude prices lost steam

Stock markets, particularly in India, do not react to the actual attack on facilities or loss of lives, but rather to the secondary impact of the increase in crude oil and other commodity prices due to the conflict

after that. Indian stock markets too did not react much to this conflict since it took place over a limited area and did not impact supply of oil or gas.

LESSONS FROM PAST CONFLICTS There are a few lessons which can be gleaned from the past geopolitical crises.

Stock markets, particularly in India, do not react to the actual attack on facilities or loss of lives, but rather to the secondary impact of the increase in crude oil and other commodity prices on corporate profitability and margins.

Two, with all global stock markets being equally sensitive to increasing crude oil prices, major oil producing countries tend to act in concert during these crises to cap the crude oil prices, by either increasing output or releasing stock from their reserves.

Crude oil prices have therefore been capped in the zone between \$120 to \$140 per barrel in recent crises.

Three, while the initial shock of the war seems to drive stock prices lower, the reaction seems limited to a few months.

In case of long drawn wars such as the Iraq war or the Russia-Ukraine conflict, other domestic and global developments seem to take over the mind-space of investors, thus limiting the declines to less than a year.

Is it different this time?

The script in the US-Israel-Iran war is developing on the same line as in earlier wars. Brent crude prices going through the roof and disruption in supply of crude oil and gas due to the closure of Strait of Hormuz is sending stock prices spiralling lower.

But a rebound is possible any time if there is cessation in hostilities or a cease-fire agreement.

However, if there is serious damage to oil and gas fields in West Asia which can impact supply for a longer term as is the case in the damage to the South Pars gas field in Iran and Qatar, then crude oil and gas prices can remain elevated for many months and this will continue to apply pressure on stock prices.

Typically, the correction caused by wars seem to last only few months in Indian stock markets, after which other influences take over. The difference this time is that the Indian stock markets is trading at a premium to other global emerging markets. Despite the overvaluation, Indian stock markets had been close to life-time highs towards the end of 2025, due to continuous demand from domestic institutional invests. The war has therefore helped in correcting some of these excesses.

It is hoped that the valuation in Indian markets moves down to reasonable levels by the time the war ends, making Indian stocks more attractive.

Community kitchens, a solution to the LPG crisis

During Covid community kitchens were successfully run in a few States. It’s time to revive them now in rural areas

Bhawna Priya
Kushankur Dey

While the PM Ujjwala scheme has covered more than 100 million rural households, the ongoing West Asia conflict has dealt a blow to them. Notably, the US-Israel-Iran conflict has disrupted about 54 per cent of India’s LPG availability.

LPG is the third-largest energy source for domestic and commercial uses. India will have consumed over 30 million tonne of LPG in 2025-26, with approximately 62 per cent of demand met through imports — most of it transiting through the Strait of Hormuz.

India’s underground LPG storage capacity in caverns at Mangaluru and Visakhapatnam amounts to roughly 0.14 million tonne, barely enough to cover one-and-a-half to two days of national consumption.

Although piped natural gas (PNG) can be an alternative energy source, the number of active PNG domestic subscribers is only 3 per cent of LPG subscribers, connected to the city gas distribution network.

So, rural people are now forced to use more solid fuels like biomass or firewood. Increased use of solid fuels leads to indoor air pollution and

household respiratory diseases. In other words, SDG 7, which aims to ensure access to affordable clean energy, remains elusive for those who cannot afford to use LPG.

Domestic LPG cylinders are sold in the black market at ₹1,500 and up to ₹3,000 for commercial ones.

The turnaround time for refilling cylinders and the reduced supply compound the crisis. The Gujarat government has cut industrial gas supply by 50 per cent. The booking interval for domestic cylinders has been extended to 25 days. As one Opposition MP bluntly put it, “the war has reached every kitchen in this country”. So, what are the plausible solutions?

COMMUNITY KITCHENS

Community kitchens can address the LPG woes of rural and marginalized communities, providing a shared space for people to assemble, plan, cook, and share nutritious, affordable food.

The logic of the community kitchen draws on thermal economics. A single large-scale kitchen serving 200 households consumes a fraction of the fuel that 200 individual stoves would use. The efficiency gains from batch cooking — centralised flame, standardised menus, reduced idle heating — can cut per-meal fuel consumption by 60-70 per cent



GAS SHORTAGE. A community solution

compared to household-level cooking.

Where LPG runs dry, solid fuels and induction cooktops have stepped in; however, these manifest individuals’ short-term coping strategy to tide them over the crisis. In contrast, the community kitchen with induction cooktops and LPG cylinders can bring people together and harness the power of collective action to manage the crisis.

Community kitchens range from volunteer-run kitchens to organised interventions. For example, Kerala’s Kudumbashree network established 1,300 community kitchens within 10 days of the Covid lockdown, serving nutritionally balanced meals to quarantined individuals, children, and older people. Gujarat’s village-wide community kitchen initiative — ‘chandanki’ — is worth mentioning. In Chhattisgarh, 2,100 SHGs

participated in an integrated food security network, with central kitchens producing partially prepared ingredients, which are distributed to smaller community units, maximizing efficiency while maintaining food quality. Madhya Pradesh’s Deendayal Rasoi Yojana serves meals at ₹5 a plate, demonstrating that state-backed community kitchens can function at scale without fiscal strain.

POLICY SUGGESTIONS

Routing prioritised LPG allocations to certified community kitchen hubs is essential rather than dispersing scarce supply to millions of individual cylinder subscribers.

The time is ripe to empower women’s SHG networks or cluster-level federations under the National Rural Livelihoods Mission with rapid disbursement funding, and to mandate CSR contributions to building community kitchen infrastructure.

To sum up, the unified community kitchens scheme unveiled during Covid needs to be executed to feed rural and marginalized people, as the flame that feeds a neighbourhood is more resilient than a thousand flames flickering separately in a thousand homes.

Bhawna and Dey teach at IIM Raipur and IIM Lucknow, respectively. Views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO EDITOR

Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Price stabilisation fund

This refers to the interview with PMEAC Chairman S Mahendra Dev (March 20). War situation has brought to surface the need for buffer stocks and the role of reserves in financial stability. The proposal to set up a ₹1 lakh crore stabilization fund has come at the right time. Beyond the functional role as a shock absorber, this fund can become a role model for financial institutions and other organisations prone to internal and external vulnerabilities. Institutions like RBI have built-in reserve systems to absorb unexpected shocks.

Moving forward, it would be

appropriate to review the need for commodity specific rolling price stabilization funds and augmenting infrastructure for storage and transportation of essential commodities.

MG Warriar
Mumbai

Conflicts and contracts

With reference to “Law in times of conflict” (March 20), dispute resolution from the maritime conflicts in extraordinary situations like the ongoing Gulf war is complex, in the absence of adequate

international regulatory support and flexible insurance underwriting clauses.

While the eagerness of every maritime trading country in ensuring the speedy movement of vessels voyaging through troubled waters, the risks involved in enforcement of the legal protection enshrined in the joint trade agreements between member countries through arbitration and other methods warns each country to have its own mechanism of guardrails. As aptly pointed out, the non-supportive insurance risk clauses excluding extraordinary

events like wars etc. result in failed contractual obligations albeit substantial revenue losses. Trade protection must be ensured through well-regulated international dispute resolution policies and insurance coverage.

Sitaram Popuri
Bengaluru

Bank issues

This refers to the news report ‘No power struggle’ in HDFC Bank; Chakraborty’s resignation ‘baffling’. Interim Chairman Keki Mistry’s assurances are measured and professional, but they do not fully

resolve the unease. When a former IAS officer of Chakraborty’s standing cites ethical incongruence and then declines to elaborate, the matter cannot be settled simply by calling it baffling. The board’s admission that no substantive discussion took place prior to the resignation is itself a governance concern. HDFC Bank’s fundamentals may well be sound, as Mistry insists, but that’s not germane to the issue on hand. The RBI should seek a fuller account — to protect its long-term credibility.
A Myilsami
Coimbatore

QUICKLY.

Crude oil falls as US, allies look to boost supply



Singapore: Crude oil prices fell on Friday as leading European nations and Japan offered to join efforts to secure safe passage for ships through the Strait of Hormuz and the US outlined moves to boost oil supply. Brent futures fell \$1.36 to \$107.29 a barrel as of 0330 GMT, while US WTI crude fell \$1.92 to \$94.22. **REUTERS**

Sugar poised for biggest weekly gain in 1-1/2 years

London: Raw sugar futures on the ICE exchange hit fresh five-month highs on Friday and were on track for their biggest weekly gain in 1-1/2 years, as the US-Israeli war on Iran kept the market on edge and pushed up energy prices. Raw sugar rose 0.9 per cent to 15.50 cents per lb at 1231GMT, heading for a weekly gain of nearly 8 per cent, its highest since September 2024. **REUTERS**

Aluminium recovers as market weighs disruptions



London: Aluminium prices steadied on Friday as investors balanced the competing impacts of the Iran war and lower supply from disrupted operations in the West Asia against weaker demand from a spike in oil prices. Benchmark 3-month aluminium on LME was up 0.5 per cent at \$3,269 a tonne by 1030 GMT, having closed down 4.4 per cent in the previous session. **REUTERS**

Lower maize prices may see farmers switch to oilseeds, pulses this kharif

AGRI WOES. Growers received 30% lower than minimum support price for the hardy cereal during the 2025-26 season

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

A section of farmers is likely to return to cultivating oilseeds and pulses in the upcoming kharif season as growers have realised lower prices this year.

The government is confident that there may be some change in the sowing pattern during the kharif season.

However, the sowing decision will depend mainly on guaranteed price for oilseeds and pulses as the procurement has highly been insignificant compared with the FCI's purchase of rice and paddy, a senior official said.

During the kharif harvest season (October-December) in 2025-26, when farmers sold their maximum produce, the all-India average maize price was ₹1,684/

quintal, down 30 per cent from the minimum support price (MSP) of ₹2,400. Still, in the hope of better prices, farmers expanded the area in the rabi season to 30.18 lakh hectares (lh) from 27.80 lh in 2024-25.

RECORD HIGH OUTPUT
The pan-India average price of maize was ₹1,781/quintal on March 18, according to the Agmarknet portal. In its second advanced estimates, the government projected maize production at a record high for the kharif season at 302.47 lakh tonnes (lt) and in the rabi season at 159.03 lt.

"Oilseeds and pulses production plan will be discussed with the States in the annual kharif conference, and accordingly, an action plan will be prepared based on the targets set by their respective mission. Prices will



OPTIMISTIC OUTPUT. The government projected maize output at a record high for the kharif season at 302.47 lt

be a key factor, and recently Madhya Pradesh announced bonus of ₹600/quintal on summer season's urad as more and more farmers were going for moong crop in the *zaid* (summer crop) season. Such intervention may help influence the sowing decision of farmers," the senior official said.

Earlier, it was expected that there would be demand

for maize from ethanol since over 2,000 crore litres of capacity have been created by distilleries.

However, the oil marketing companies bought only about 1,000-1,100 crore litres to meet the 20 per cent blending target, resulting in under utilisation of plants.

Besides, the government also allotted rice for ethanol, limiting the scope for grain-

based plants. The sugar industry also makes ethanol and sells to OMCs, though its share was low this year.

PROCUREMENT SOON
The Economic Survey mentioned the point that as per policy decision it was expected that rice farmers would shift to maize, but while rice area increased, maize area, too, increased because of shifting from pulses and oilseeds.

Agriculture Minister Shrivraj Singh Chouhan on Friday said that government purchase of wheat and paddy would commence shortly, noting that rabi crop production had been exceptionally high this season.

He said agencies, including NAFED and NCCF, would procure tur, masur and urad, and whatever farmers wished to sell, the

entire quantity would be bought so that market prices do not fall below MSP.

He also directed officials to coordinate with State governments for accurate assessment of crop losses after unseasonal rainfall and hailstorms damaged standing rabi crops, including wheat in some States.

Chairing a review meeting, Chouhan said adverse weather had hit several States at a time when crops were ripe and ready for harvest.

"Not only did it rain, but many areas also experienced hailstorms, resulting in damage to the crops," he told reporters after the meeting. The Minister directed officials to immediately establish contact with State governments to identify specific locations where crop damage had occurred.

Cotton may gain as pricey crude oil drives up MMF prices

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

With the prices of man-made fibres (MMF), such as polyester, moving up in tandem with crude oil following the ongoing war in West Asia, cotton stakeholders see demand coming back for the natural fibre.

Polyester fibre prices have moved up by 10-25 per cent within days of crude oil moving up.

Taking these developments into account, the Cotton Association of India (CAI) expects consumption of cotton to go up by 10 lakh bales for the current season 2025-26 ending September, compared to the projections made in January.

The prices of MMFs have gone up substantially because of this war, which resulted in higher crude prices. So, many mills which are using MMFs or have converted to MMFs may come back to cotton, said Vinay N Kotak, President, CAI.

Further, the rising international prices of cotton and the weakening of the rupee against the dollar have also made cotton imports costlier, he said.

REVISED PRICE
Cotton futures on the ICE have gained from around 60.65 cents per pound in early March to a high of 69.34 this week, before easing to the current levels of 67.77.

Following the firming trend, the Cotton Corpora-

tion of India has raised the prices by ₹1,400 per candy (356 kg) over the past few days. CCI increased the prices in three instances of ₹500, ₹700 and ₹200, totalling ₹1,400 per candy in the past few days.

CCI Chairman and Managing Director Lalit Kumar Gupta said the increase in sale price is in line with the global trend and that good demand is coming for cotton. CCI has procured over 104 lakh bales (170 kg) at the minimum support price during the 2025-26 marketing season.

Recently, the demand for Indian cotton yarn has gone up from countries such as China, Bangladesh and Vietnam, with disruption in the global supply chain due to



BACK IN DEMAND. Recently, demand for cotton yarn has gone up from countries such as China, Bangladesh and Vietnam

the ongoing war. Ramanuj Das Boob, a sourcing agent in Raichur, said the prices of MMFs had gone up by ₹10-30 per kg, following the rise in crude prices. Unlike cotton, MMF

prices are fully dependent on petrochemicals and are likely to remain volatile. The balance between cotton and MMF will depend on crude stability.

Futher, Das Boob said the

W Asia crisis hits orthodox tea market at Kochi sales

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

The West Asia crisis has started affecting orthodox tea markets at Kochi auctions, with the average price of the brew declining by around ₹10 per kg. According to traders, the price drop is the highest in the recent period.

The auctioneers Forbes, Ewart & Figgis said exporters to the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) and neighbouring countries were the ones who were active, West Asia buyers were selective and subdued in sale 12. There was some enquiries from upcountry markets.

The offered quantity in orthodox leaf was 1,84,273 kg with 96 per cent of the offerings being sold. The price of good broken was declined, while the whole leaf priced dipped a tad.

CTC leaf market tended to rule easy with 26,000 kg being offered on sale. All sec-

tions of the trade showed interest in buying.

CIS MARKET TAKE LEAD
Anil George, Chairman, Tea Trade Association of Cochin, said there was firm demand for orthodox teas and the buying interest was led by CIS markets.

Overall, there was a wide gap in the quality of teas on offer at the auction, with high-grade teas fetching better prices.

The CTC dust market ruled lower, with good liquoring teas slipping by ₹1-2. The quantity offered was 6,18,033 kg with 90 per cent of the offerings being sold. All blenders together bought 78 per cent of the total CTC quantity offered.

Traders said domestic buying was subdued in the sale and they attributed the reason to a drop in the consumption of tea due to the closure of wayside eateries and hotels on account of LPG shortage.

As Iran war prolongs, PMO asks Agri Min for measures to combat fertilizer shortage

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

The Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare (MoFW) has been asked by the Prime Minister's Office to brief it on the likely crisis the agriculture sector could face, particularly the shortage of fertilizers and other chemicals.

The development comes in the wake of the war in West Asia, which looks to be prolonging due to Iran's resistance and retaliation against the US-Israel axis. It also comes at a time when drought-bearing El Nino has raised concerns among all stakeholders, including the government.

The MoFW has, in turn, asked various associations, particularly the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (Ficci) and the Indian Agricultural



PROPOSED REMEDIES. Industry moots focus on biologicals and bio-additives to overcome problems in short- and long-term

Research Institute (IARI), to come up with suggestions to tackle the situation.

Though the Centre's initial concern is to tide over any problem that may develop ahead of the kharif sowing season, it has also sought short- and long-term measures to overcome any such problems in future.

Renuka Diwan, Co-founder and Chief Executive Officer of BioPrime Ag-

riSolutions Pvt Ltd, told *businessline* that her company was approached on how biologicals and bio-additives could help overcome the situation. Stating that several chemicals are derived from petroleum sources, she said biostimulants have been impacted due to the supply chain disruptions.

"It is time for home-grown technologies; they can contribute to food secur-

ity. Microbes can help in nitrogen fixation, and the use of urea can be reduced," she said.

POLICY SUPPORT
Industry sources said they told the MoFW that bionutrition, which refers to advanced biological and bioadditive technologies, could reduce fertilizer dependence significantly, while maintaining productivity.

"These are proven technologies, validated by ICAR universities, regulatory compliant and already commercialised with some multinational companies," said a source, who did not wish to be identified.

Bio-additives can enhance nutrient use efficiency, and use of biostimulants and enhancers has to be extended. "We need to establish pathways through policy support and private-public partnerships," Diwan said.

Iran war puts pesticide industry at risk: CropLife

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

CropLife India, which represents research-driven crop protection companies, has said that the disruption in supply chains and key shipping routes due to the West Asia conflict is likely to impact input costs by 20-25 per cent for the crop protection industry, leading to a rise in costs for the farmers accordingly.

Quoting Ankur Aggarwal, Chairman of CropLife India and Executive Chairman and Managing Director of Crystal Crop Protection Ltd, a media statement said on Friday that the disruptions may lead to a shortage of certain crop protection products during a critical agriculture season, impacting yield and the quality of produce.

"The industry is expected to see lower capacity utilisation in this period across

technical and formulation plants, and this may affect industry earnings and employment as well, particularly among the MSMSEs. At this juncture, the industry requests for support and incentives on the energy front to enhance local production and capacity," he said.

ILLICIT PRODUCTS
He said CropLife India's commitment is to working closely with the government to support a science-based, predictable and globally aligned regulatory environment that promotes innovation while safeguarding farmer interests, consumer safety and environmental sustainability.

"The supply gaps and volatility could spur circulation of illicit, counterfeit or substandard products; therefore, it is critical that we remain vigilant and activate all monitoring mechanisms," Aggarwal said.

Edible oil sector seeks balanced policy

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

The Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA) has said the vegetable oil and oil seed sector stands at a crucial juncture shaped by global disruptions, weather uncertainties and domestic fundamentals.

In his monthly letter to SEA members, Sanjeev Asthana, SEA President, said a balanced approach combining policy support, market intelligence and stakeholder collaboration will be essential to navigate the evolving landscape effectively.

Referring to the prevailing global geopolitical situation, he said India, which is heavily dependent on imports for crude oil and LPG, faces increased procurement costs

and logistical uncertainties under such circumstances.

"Elevated crude oil prices directly impact the cost of production and transportation of edible oils, thereby exerting inflationary pressure on the domestic market. Additionally, volatility in freight and insurance premiums further compounds the landed cost of imported edible oils, necessitating strict monitoring, cautious procurement strategies and policy support to maintain price stability," he said.

EASING BURDEN
He said the coordinated efforts across the export-import ecosystem will significantly ease the operational burden on exporters and ensure continuity of trade during this challenging period.

Recent global weather assessments indicate a shift

away from earlier La Nina expectations, with emerging signals now pointing towards a strong El Nino, potentially a 'Super El Nino' phase, as indicated by the Australian Bureau of Meteorology and supported by the US NOAA.

Globally, the impact may be mixed, with possible production risks in Asia but relatively favourable conditions in parts of South America.

"However, for India, this raises concerns of below-normal monsoon rainfall, which could adversely affect kharif oilseed sowing, leading to lower acreage and tighter domestic supplies," Asthana said, adding, "In this backdrop, proactive measures in domestic production and calibrated import planning will be crucial to ensure supply stability and price balance."

Chicken prices soar on bird mortality, reduced weight

Rates are ruling in the ₹270-340 per kg range in retail markets

V Sajeew Kumar
KV Kurmanath
Kochi/Hyderabad

With rising temperatures leading to bird mortality and reduced bird weight, chicken prices have surged to record highs in some cities across the country. Prices are ruling in the ₹270-340 per kg range in retail markets, hitting the highest price so far.

This comes at a time when egg prices have fallen significantly owing to a market glut caused by the stoppage of exports to the Gulf region.

"Because of growing temperatures, birds don't gain weight. The average

weight of the bird comes down to 1.5-1.75 kg in summer against ₹2.5-3 kg in other seasons. This will directly impact the farmgate prices and the retail price," K Mohan Reddy, President of the Telangana Poultry Federation, told *businessline*.

An industry veteran pointed out issues related to reduced bird production. Officials from the Poultry Farmers and Breeders Association of Maharashtra said chicken prices in the State are rising due to a widening demand-supply gap. Chicken prices are increasing by ₹20-30 every week.

Input costs such as feed



and logistics remain elevated, putting additional pressure on farmgate prices. Traders said if the current trend continues, retail chicken prices could firm up further in the coming weeks, although a sudden drop in demand or improved weather conditions could stabilise the market.

"Prices have moved up as

poultry players across the country had cut down on production of commercial broilers after facing huge losses for about 5-6 months from April-November last year as the prices had gone below the cost of production," Naveen Pasuparthi, President, Karnataka Poultry Farmers and Breeders Association.

MULTIPLE FACTORS
Ex-farm prices of live birds are hovering around ₹146 per kg currently, against around ₹90 during November.

Pramod TK, Kerala President of the Poultry Farmers & Traders Samithy, said that broiler chicken prices

in the State had risen sharply over the past two months, touching ₹171 per kg in the retail market and ₹126 at the farmgate.

He attributed the price surge to multiple factors, including increased bird mortality due to intense summer heat, and viral diseases reported in parts of the country.

Despite the price rise, demand has remained strong, supported by the Ramadan season. Kerala's weekly consumption of chicken is estimated around 2.25 crore birds, he said.

(With inputs from Radheshyam Jadhav in Pune and Vishwanath Kulkarni in Bengaluru)

QUICKLY.

300 illegal gambling, betting sites blocked

New Delhi: In a crackdown on illegal online betting and gambling, the Centre has blocked as many as 300 sites and apps. With this move, the number of blocked or prohibited sites now stands at nearly 4,800. According to sources, the blocked sites and apps were sports betting platforms; online casinos offering slots, roulette or live dealer tables and betting exchanges functioning like peer-to-peer betting marketplaces. Action was also taken on *satta* and *matka* gambling networks besides real-money card and casino game apps, the sources added. OUR BUREAU

RCom case: CBI questions Anil Ambani for 2nd day

New Delhi: The CBI on Friday questioned industrialist Anil Ambani for over six hours for the second day in connection with a ₹2,929-crore cheating case, registered against Reliance Communications Ltd and him on a complaint by the State Bank of India, officials said. PTI

Telangana’s FY27 budget pegged at ₹3.24 lakh cr; debt tops ₹5.6 lakh cr

NETTY GRITTIES. State will restructure ₹25,612 crore high-interest loans to ease debt burden

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad

Amid mounting public debt of ₹5.62 lakh crore weighing on the State’s finances, Telangana Deputy Chief Minister and Finance Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka presented the ₹3.24 lakh crore budget for 2026-27.

To manage the debt burden, the government announced restructuring of ₹25,612 crore in high-interest loans.

To meet the increased capital expenditure and fund welfare schemes, he indicated that the State would go for open-market loans to the tune of ₹73,383 crore and ₹5,500 crore from the Centre as a loan.

The Deputy Chief Minister pegged the revenue expenditure at ₹2,34,406 crore and capital expenditure at ₹47,267 crore.

The budget focused on welfare schemes, even as the

Opposition Bharat Rashtira Samithi (BRS) flayed the government for failing to implement the six guarantees promised by the ruling Congress government during the election campaign.

Presenting the budget in the Assembly on Friday, Vikramarka said that the government had decided to restructure certain components of loans that were taken at a very high interest rate to reduce the debt servicing burden on the exchequer.

Blaming the erstwhile government for placing a severe burden on the State’s economy due to excessive borrowings, the Deputy CM announced the restructuring of ₹25,612 crore in high-interest loans.

The high-interest loans were renegotiated so that we pay a lower interest rate, extending the repayment period, and lengthening the principal tenure to 20–39 years.

Through this debt struc-

KEY SECTORAL ALLOCATIONS

- Agriculture and Cooperation: ₹23,179 crore
- Power subsidy: ₹14,000 crore
- Energy: ₹21,285 crore
- Health and medical: ₹13,679 crore
- Irrigation: ₹22,615 crore
- Education: ₹26,674 crore

turing, the amount payable from 2025-26 to 2031-32 was reduced from ₹34,058 crore to ₹11,915 crore, thereby reducing cash outflows by ₹22,142 crore.

FINANCE COMMISSION

Stating that the State received far less from the Union Government than what it contributed to it, he



Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, Telangana Deputy CM and Finance Minister

said, “What we receive through tax devolution from the Centre is, on an average, 42 paise for every rupee we pay. This is serious injustice to States that are controlling population, increasing their own revenues, and serving as the backbone of the national economy.”

“To rectify this historical imbalance, our government

forcefully presented its case before the 16th Finance Commission,” he said.

“We could persuade the Commission to consider not only factors such as population and income distance in the tax devolution formula, but also ‘State GSDP’ as a key parameter. As a result, Telangana’s share has been increased from 2.102 per cent to 2.174 per cent,” he said.

He said that Telangana’s IT exports had reached ₹3.13 lakh crore, generating employment for over 9.39 lakh people.

PUSH FOR SCHEMES

The Finance Minister has allocated ₹18,000 crore for the ‘Rythu Bharosa’ scheme (₹12,000 in financial assistance for farmers), ₹14,861 crore for Cheyutha pensions, ₹1,143 crore for Rajeev Arogya Sri, ₹4,305 crore for Mahalakshmi (free bus service), and ₹5,500 crore for the Indiramma housing scheme.

Tap CSS, plug gaps, rationalise taxes: Reddy on revenue generation

Richa Mishra
Hyderabad

The top bureaucratic and political team of the Telangana government acknowledges the several challenges and financial pressure to meet the 2026-27 budget proposals presented by Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, who also holds the Finance portfolio. The budget reflects a dual strategy — ensuring inclusive development through welfare while promoting growth through infrastructure investment.

Bhatti’s budget proposal for FY27 puts expenditure at ₹3,24,234 crore, revenue expenditure of ₹2,34,406 crore, and capital expenditure of ₹47,267 crore.

“What we have put is [the] estimate. We know that raising the estimated revenue will not be easy, but we will put our best effort. We will

focus on non-tax revenue. We will try to plug leakages and do rationalisation of taxes wherever feasible,” a senior State Finance Ministry official told *businessline*.

Chief Minister Revanth Reddy, responding to a question from *businessline* on how he defines the budget and the avenues for revenue generation, said, “The budget is not just a fine balance between welfare and development, but is also a futuristic budget.”

“We have action plans to upgrade ourselves,” he said, adding that the State government has identified revenue generators to fulfil the promises/assurances it has made.

Endorsing what his officials said, Reddy stated, “The focus essentially was on tapping maximum funds through Centrally-sponsored schemes and other sources. The government has identified lacunae in the GST and mining sec-



A Revanth Reddy, Telangana Chief Minister

Reddy stressed that the loopholes and leakages have been plugged to strengthen the State’s finances.

Bhatti, too, was confident that the path adopted will make the State future ready, even as Opposition parties in Telangana labelled the budget as a deceptive and misleading document.

REINS ON THE PURSE

The State is dealing with an imbalance between revenue and expenditure and has tightened its purse strings to meet its welfare proposals.

According to Govindapuram Suresh, Assistant Professor of Economics IFMR Graduate School of Business, Krea, “The Telangana budget 2026–27 presents an expansionary fiscal stance, aiming to balance welfare commitments with growth-oriented investments, while facing increasing pressure on fiscal sustainability.”

tors because of which these resources could not be tapped effectively by the previous government. Steps were taken to rectify these lapses, as a result of which GST revenue crossed ₹4,000 crore in a month. It has never before crossed ₹3,000 crore in a month.”

Unorganised, gig workers meet Delhi CM ahead of Budget, seek job security

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday held an interaction with gig workers and unorganised labourers to gather inputs for the upcoming State budget, with participants flagging issues ranging from job security to lack of basic urban infrastructure.

GRIEVANCES AIRED

Workers from the delivery and transport sectors highlighted structural challenges, including the absence

of formal employment status and inadequate facilities across the city. Several participants called for recognising gig workers as employees instead of “partners”, arguing that such a move would improve job security and provide protection against arbitrary practices.

Workers also pointed to the need for gender-sensitive measures. Suggestions included maternity benefits for women workers and the creation of rest stops and support facilities across the city through public-private partnerships.

EC tightens noose around AI usage; polling booths to come up in high-rise communities

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Tamil Nadu Chief Electoral Officer on Friday issued guidelines focusing on use of AI, political advertisements and voter services’ accessibility in relation to the 2026 Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly elections.

Tightening the norms for AI-generated content and to tackle deepfakes and synthetic media, the EC has mandated labelling of any AI-generated or digitally altered content as so, while misleading content that impersonates individuals is prohibited.

“All AI-generated or digit-



ally altered content must carry a clear and prominent label such as ‘AI generated’, ‘digitally enhanced’ or ‘synthetic content’, covering at least 10 per cent of the display area or initial 10 per cent duration for audio content,” the guideline said. Such content

must be removed within 3 hours of detection/reporting, it added.

VOTER TURNOUT

Similarly, to improve urban voter turnout, the EC said it has initiated polling facilities within high-rise residential

complexes and group housing societies. “14 polling stations have been established in such locations during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) 2026,” it said, without naming the 14 locations.

The EC also said that all political advertisements on electronic and social media must be approved by the Media Certification and Monitoring Committee (MCMC) at the State or District level.

Recognised parties must apply at least three days in advance, while others seven days prior, the Commission added.

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Telangana per capita income at ₹4.19 lakh, 1.9x national average

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad

The per capita income of Telangana has risen to ₹4,18,931 in 2025-26, reflecting a 10.2 per cent growth against the country’s 6.9 per cent.

This is ₹1,99,356 or 1.9 times, more than the national average.

Telangana’s Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) at current prices stands at ₹17.82 lakh crore, reflecting a growth of 10.7 per cent over the last year’s figure.

“We contribute 5 per cent to the country’s Gross Domestic Product of ₹3,57,13,886 crore. The State’s economy grew by 2.7 percentage points more than the national growth rate of 8 per cent,” said Deputy Chief Minister and Finance Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka. Presenting the budget in the Assembly here on Friday, he said that the State has emerged as a strong growth engine for the country.

“Though the country’s growth rate is slowing down, our State’s growth rate is going up. At current prices, the national GDP growth rate, which was 9.8 per cent in 2024-25, declined to 8 per cent in 2025-26. But, Telangana’s GSDP growth rate increased from 10.6 per cent in

2024-25 to 10.7 per cent in 2025-26,” he said.

“This proves that the policies being implemented by our government are moving in the right direction,” he said.

He said the State was attempting to become a \$1 trillion by 2036 from the current \$200 billion. “We will become a \$3 trillion economy by 2047. To achieve this objective, we are preparing special sector-wise plans,” he said.

MUD SLINGING

He alleged that the erstwhile BRS government had failed to utilise the funds under the Centrally sponsored schemes (CSS) from 2014 to 2023.

“Even the funds sanctioned by the Centre were not spent for the implementation of the respective schemes, and were diverted for other needs. As a result, the subsequent instalments due from the Centre were stopped, causing irreparable loss to Telangana,” he said.

“The State government has secured ₹7,072 crore in Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS) funds this financial year, a significant increase from ₹4,826 crore in 2021-22. The State is striving to secure even more funds,” he said.

Women, minorities, tribals anchor TMC’s poll manifesto push for 4th term

Press Trust of India
Kolkata

Betting on the social coalition that has powered Mamata Banerjee’s political dominance over the past 15 years, the TMC’s 2026 poll manifesto focuses on women, minorities and SC/ST communities in a calculated bid to blunt the BJP’s challenge and secure a fourth straight term.

Unveiled with 10 *pratigyas* (pledges), the manifesto blends welfare expansion, minority outreach and targeted tribal initiatives.

At the centre of the document lies the Lakshmir Bhandar scheme.

Banerjee announced a ₹500 hike in the scheme, taking the monthly assistance to ₹1,700 for SC/ST women and ₹1,500 for women in the general category.

Beyond financial assistance, the manifesto promises to increase women’s labour force participation from 44.7 per cent to 50 per cent in the next five years by expanding employment opportunities, strengthening self-help groups (SHG) and increasing credit circulation in the SHG ecosystem, among others.

Muslims constitute nearly 30 per cent of the electorate.

MINORITY OUTREACH

The manifesto’s minority outreach includes promises to protect and utilise Waqf properties for community welfare, expand job-oriented courses at Aliah University, and introduce soft-skill training in 27 industrial training institutes located in minority-dominated areas.

It also seeks to consolidate support among SCs and STs.

Drops of relief: Kashmir’s saffron industry finds its breath

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

Fresh spells of rain across Kashmir have brought much-needed relief to the region’s saffron industry, which had been reeling under a prolonged dry spell that threatened crop health and future yields.

Over the past few days, continuous rainfall has lashed the Valley, offering respite to thousands of farmers and workers associated with saffron cultivation. In south Kashmir’s Pampore area, the epicentre of the world’s most expensive spice, the showers have revived saffron fields spread across vast tracts of land, raising hopes for improved production in the coming season.

Abdul Majeed Wani, President, All Jammu and Kashmir Saffron Growers Association, said the rainfall had come at a critical time for the crop. “The rain has brought much-needed relief to farmers. The prolonged dry spell had severely affected vegetation,” he said.

Saffron is highly sensitive to climatic variations and depends on precise weather conditions during different stages of its growth cycle. After the flowering season, which typically runs from mid-October to mid-November, the crop enters its vegetative phase. During this period, long, grass-like leaves emerge and carry out photosynthesis, enabling the plant to store energy and develop new daughter corms underground.

These corms are crucial



INSTILLING LIFE. In south Kashmir’s Pampore area, the epicentre of the world’s most expensive spice, the showers have revived saffron fields spread across tracts of land NISSAR AHMAD

for the following year’s crop, as they determine the strength and productivity of the next flowering season.

DRY SPELL

Official data highlights the extent of the moisture deficit that had raised concerns among growers. Pulwama and Budgam, the two main

saffron-producing districts, recorded a sharp shortfall in rainfall between October 1 and December 3, 2025. Pulwama received 29.4 mm of rainfall against a normal of 47.6 mm, a deficit of 38 per cent, while Budgam recorded 23.1 mm compared with a normal of 54.2 mm, marking a 57 per cent defi-

cit, one of the steepest in the Valley.

The dry conditions persisted into the winter months. In February this year, Srinagar recorded just 5.3 mm of precipitation, the lowest for the month since 1960, according to meteorological data.

Farmers said the recent rains could help reverse some of the damage.

“The rainfall will help in the development of corms, which in turn will increase production,” said Ali Mohammad, a saffron grower from Pampore.

While growers remain cautiously optimistic, they say sustained and timely precipitation will be crucial in the coming months to ensure a healthy crop cycle and secure livelihoods dependent on the prized spice.

QUICKLY.

Zomato increases platform fee by 19%

New Delhi: Zomato has raised its platform fee, charged from users, to ₹14.90 per order up from ₹12.50, reflecting a 19.2 per cent increase, according to information available on its app. Platform fees have been witnessing steady hikes by food delivery and aggregators. The food delivery company had last raised its platform fee to ₹12.50 per order in September last year from ₹10. When contacted, Zomato did not comment on the matter. The latest hike comes when players across sectors are coping with escalating costs amidst the West Asia conflict. **OUR BUREAU**

Apitoria Pharma receives green light from USFDA

Hyderabad: An API manufacturing facility of Apitoria Pharma, a wholly-owned subsidiary of Aurobindo Pharma in Pashamylaram here, has received an establishment inspection report from the USFDA. It classified the facility as ‘voluntary action indicated’ and the inspection is now “closed”. **OUR BUREAU**

Govt planning expanded worker cover

WELFARE PUSH. Labour Ministry examining domestic, international models to draw up social security scheme for gig employees

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The Union Labour and Employment Ministry is considering expanding social security with insurance cover to at least 32 crore unorganised, gig and platform workers to fulfil the mandate provided by the four Labour Codes, which are in the final stages of implementation. The Employees’ State Insurance Corporation (ESIC), under the Labour and Employment Ministry, is going through various domestic and international models in its initial deliberations to arrive at a suitable scheme for expanding social security coverage for the unorganised, gig and platform workers, Ministry sources said.

SUBSIDY MODEL Broadly, the Ministry is exploring worker’s voluntary contribution plus government subsidy to move forward in this direction to overcome constrained public resources. Presently, it is voluntary for the unorgan-

ised workers. After the proposed scheme is implemented, it will be easy for unorganised workers to onboard because large numbers will reduce the premium for the proposed insurance scheme, Ministry sources said. “The social security can be tax funded or partly tax funded. But the most important part is how to generate income since the government does not have money to make the scheme completely tax funded,” they said. The Ministry has roped in the VV Giri National Labour Institute to carry out impact analysis on the four Labour Codes. Director General of the Institute Arvind told *businessline*: “The survey will begin after three to four months to assess the impact of various aspects of the four codes on workers and employers.”

TAX FUNDED India has multiple welfare schemes, which operate mostly on a fully tax funded model and a few on contribution basis, but they are fragmented. Key among the cent-



SUPPORT FRAMEWORK. The Ministry is exploring voluntary contribution from workers plus government subsidy to overcome constrained public resources

ral schemes are the Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana, an accident insurance (₹2 lakh cover) available to individuals aged between 18 and 70 years, at a very low annual premium of ₹20, auto-debited from individual bank accounts. Likewise, the Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana is a life insurance scheme that provides ₹2 lakh cover against death due to any cause to bank account holders aged between 18 and 50 years.

for the unorganised, gig and platform workers.

A BIG CHALLENGE The Ministry is looking to plug the social security gap, which officials believe is very challenging, given its volume and the complex nature of the unorganised sector *per se*.

As per the e-shram portal, there are 31 crore unorganised registered workers but the figure goes up to 50 crore, if the NITI Aayog is to be believed. There are about one crore gig and platform workers.

Since the welfare schemes have to be provided to the workers and their families, 32 crore multiplied by four (taking the average size of a family of four) comes to 128 crore persons.

The Ministry’s idea is to secure the lives of unorganised, gig and platform workers. Such workers are mostly spread across 32 cities, which includes the metros and 23 tier-II cities.

The Code on Social Security, 2020, under Section 109, tasks the Central government with framing and noti-

fying the welfare schemes for — life and disability cover, health and maternity benefits, old age protection, education and any other benefits — for the unorganised workers.

Similarly, the State governments, too, have been authorised to frame rules and laws for unorganised workers for their provident fund, employment injury benefit, housing, education of children, skill upgradation, funeral assistance and old age homes.

Section 114 of the Social Security Code, however, covers gig workers and platform workers.

The Code also specifies funding of the welfare schemes by the Centre, the States or by both and through corporate social responsibility programmes.

Several countries provide insurance (health, accident, life, pension or unemployment) to unorganised/informal workers either through state-funded, contributory or hybrid systems. One of the most cited models for informal worker insurance is that of Thailand.

Fewer flights likely during summer schedule, say sources

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Airlines’ summer flight schedule is expected to be lower by around 10-15 per cent on a year-on-year basis, as well as compared to the ongoing winter schedule, as revised pilot rest norms, along with capacity constraints, continue to weigh on the sector.

Sources told *businessline* that a number of factors, including a shortage of aircraft and pilots, as also rising operational costs and recent

regulatory interventions on airfares have impacted the flight schedule.

As a result, the upcoming schedule, applicable from March 29, 2026, is expected to have 10-15 per cent less flights than the summer schedule of 2025, which had 25,610 weekly departures, and the winter schedule of 2025, which had 26,495 weekly departures.

The expected schedule assumes significance ahead of the peak summer travel season due to higher passenger demand.

Aircraft availability con-



tinues to be a key concern for carriers.

As of now, a section of airlines’ fleet remains grounded due to supply chain disruptions, maintenance issues, and delays in deliveries, limiting the ability of carriers to

fully utilise their scheduled capacity.

Besides, the implementation of revised flight duty time limitation (FDTL) norms has begun to impact crew utilisation, further constraining operational flexibility.

THE INDIGO CRISIS

In December 2025, IndiGo faced significant flight disruptions linked to operational and crew-related constraints, which led to widespread cancellations across the country, leaving thousands of passengers

stranded and drawing regulatory scrutiny.

IndiGo reported the cancellation of 2,507 flights and delays to 1,852 flights between December 3 and 5, 2025. The disruptions affected more than three lakh passengers across the country.

Airlines are now recalibrating schedules to ensure compliance with regulatory requirements while maintaining operational reliability.

Rising volatility in crude oil prices is adding to cost pressures for carriers, at a

time when their margins remain under strain.

At present, the West Asia conflict has contributed to higher aviation turbine fuel prices.

JET FUEL COSTS

Jet fuel costs across the four major metro cities, Delhi, Kolkata, Mumbai and Chennai, rose by 5.81 per cent, or approximately ₹5,215.50 per kilolitre, in the latest revision.

In Delhi specifically, the price increased by ₹5,244.75 on March 1, representing a rise of about 5.74 per cent,

compared to the February 1 levels.

The prices include Central Excise Duty and State Value Added Tax, and are revised by the oil marketing companies on the first day of every month.

Additionally, the Centre imposed temporary airfare caps in early December after taking cognisance of unusually high fares amid flight disruptions.

At that time, the Ministry of Civil Aviation invoked its regulatory powers to ensure fair and reasonable fares across affected routes.

PM Modi to inaugurate Noida International Airport on March 28

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi is set to inaugurate the much-awaited Noida International Airport at Jewar in Greater Noida on March 28, sources told *businessline*.

Notably, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath had earlier indicated the date during an event in Lucknow on March 18, stating that the Prime Minister had been invited to formally open the greenfield airport project.

Notably, the airport inauguration is part of the celebration marking the completion of nine years of Adityanath’s government in Uttar Pradesh.

Under these celebrations, the state has identified nine themes, including infrastructure, under which the inauguration is taking place.

The inauguration comes after the airport cleared key regulatory milestones, moving closer to the start of commercial operations after multiple missed deadlines.

SECURITY CLEARANCES

Earlier this month, the NIA secured both security and aerodrome clearances, marking a significant step in its operational readiness.

The Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) has granted final security clearance for domestic passenger operations as well as domestic and international cargo services.

Following this, the airport received its aerodrome licence from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), certifying that it meets regulatory requirements related to safety systems, operational procedures,

infrastructure, navigation aids and emergency response. In technical terms, the certification confirms compliance with the DGCA’s Civil Aviation Re-

quirements for airside infrastructure and flight operations.

The next regulatory step involves approval of the Aerodrome Security Programme by the BCAS, after which full-scale commercial operations can commence.

A major operational milestone had already been achieved in December 2024, when IndiGo conducted a validation flight using an Airbus A320 to test approach procedures, navigation aids and air traffic control systems at the airport.

Airport authorities say all core infrastructure is now in place. Concessions have been awarded across key segments, including ground handling, in-flight catering, fuel supply, cargo services, retail, food and beverage, and hospitality.

Communication and navigation systems have also been commissioned by the Airports Authority of India.

The airport is now working closely with airline partners to finalise routes, slot approvals and network plans. IndiGo will be the launch carrier, while Akasa Air plans to operate both domestic and international services. Air India Express is also expected to begin operations from the airport.

Discussions are ongoing with other domestic airlines, as well as carriers from West Asia and Southeast Asia.

BUS SERVICES

Mobility options will include intercity and long-haul bus services, airport taxis and app-based cab aggregators, supported by intelligent traffic management systems.

Flipkart CFO steps down ahead of IPO

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Ahead of its planned public listing, Flipkart’s Group Chief Financial Officer Sriram Venkataraman has stepped down, the company said, marking a key leadership change as it advances IPO preparations.

Venkataraman will remain with the firm for a transition period to ensure continuity and a smooth handover. During this time, Ravi Iyer will oversee the broader finance organisation.

Separately, Flipkart has appointed Nishant Verman as Senior Vice-President, Corporate Development and Partnerships.

WTO panel adopts mechanism to track trade concerns

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

The World Trade Organisation (WTO) has adopted a new decision to make its Committee on Market Access (CMA) more outcome-driven, introducing a structured system to track the resolution of trade concerns raised by member countries.

Thirty-three trade concerns were raised at the two-day meeting of the CMA on March 16-17, of which six were related to India’s policies. These included import restrictions on pulses, tyres, pocket lighters, air-conditioners and its quality control orders. India, too, is party to concerns raised on seven issues against other members, including the EU’s

controversial Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) and the EU Deforestation Regulation.

As part of the reform, a new standing agenda item, titled ‘Reports on resolution of trade concerns’, will be included in all formal CMA meetings. This will allow members to update the committee on the progress made in addressing previously raised issues before taking up new concerns.

“Under this new standing agenda item, members will be invited to report on previously raised trade concerns for which a resolution has been reached. Members may also inform the Secretariat at any time that a trade concern has been resolved. In these cases and for transparency purposes, the Chairperson



TRANSPARENCY BOOST. Under the new standing agenda item, members will be invited to report on previously raised trade concerns for which a resolution has been reached

will report such resolution at the CMA’s following formal meeting,” per the decision adopted by the CMA on March 16.

EXPLICIT PROOF

Importantly, the decision clarifies that the absence of

discussion on a trade concern in subsequent meetings will not imply that it has been resolved. Only explicit confirmation from the concerned members will determine its status.

The framework also preserves members’ legal rights.

Even if a concern is recorded as resolved or partially resolved, countries remain free to raise the issue again in the CMA or other WTO bodies or to pursue dispute settlement under the WTO’s Dispute Settlement Understanding.

To prevent concerns from falling into limbo, the Secretariat will conduct a review every two years of issues that have not been discussed for at least two consecutive years.

It will reach out to the members involved to ascertain their status and prepare a report for transparency.

Additionally, a new section will be included in the CMA’s annual report to the Council for Trade in Goods, providing an overview of the status of all trade concerns.

How Anand Mahindra selects top leaders for strategic roles

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Anand Mahindra’s trade secret for hiring top leadership is disarmingly simple: A 90-minute, unstructured conversation.

No scorecards, no preset questions — just an attempt to observe one thing: Curiosity and how a leader will behave when there are no scripts to follow, when no one is watching.

At its core, Mahindra’s model links leadership, risk and execution into a single system — one that allows the group to place early bets without losing strategic discipline. Mahindra outlined these ideas in a recent interview with McKinsey, where he spoke about leadership, risk-taking and the group’s transformation playbook.

Within the Mahindra Group, that conversation is not an outlier; it feeds into a larger system through its ESEE framework — envision, structure, enable, energise — with “Enable” at its core: Identifying leaders who

can take on complex, evolving business challenges and execute without constant direction.

If “envision” defines the future and “structure” builds the organisation, “enable” determines who is trusted to carry that strategy forward.

PERFORMING ABILITY

That philosophy has shaped both leadership decisions and business bets at Mahindra.

Veejay Nakra’s trajectory is a case in point.

After working on the launch of the Scorpio SUV in 2002 and going on to establish it as its first brand manager, Nakra demonstrated his ability to build and scale a product — before being tapped to lead the group’s South Africa business, a move that raised eyebrows internally but has since paid off with Mahindra emerging as one of the fastest-growing auto companies in that market.

As the group expanded, this leadership-first approach was scaled under CEO Anish Shah, whom



No scorecards, no preset questions — just an attempt to observe one thing: Curiosity, and how a leader will behave when there are no scripts to follow, when no one is watching

ANAND MAHINDRA
Mahindra Group Chairman



Mahindra credits with fine-tuning the fast-track development of high-potential talent. The underlying idea is simple: People stay when they grow, not because of perks or pay.

STRATEGY & RISK

Mahindra has often traced this approach to his early training in filmmaking, where he learned to spot patterns, build narratives and empathise with characters. Leadership, in his view, is not very different — under-

standing motives, shaping a story and inspiring people to play their part.

That perspective has also informed how he approaches risk: Not as a binary bet, but as a constructed narrative with multiple outcomes.

That lens was evident when the company launched the Scorpio SUV in 2002 — a move widely seen as risky at the time.

Internally, however, it reflected what Mahindra describes as “asymmetric risk-taking” — where the down-

side is limited but the upside can be transformational.

The same logic applied more than a decade later when the group began investing in electric vehicles, long before the market gained traction and at a time when the decision drew scepticism. With India’s EV market now accelerating and Mahindra’s electric SUV portfolio gaining ground, those early bets are being reassessed.

Within the company, they are seen as an extension of the same playbook: Envision early, structure for scale and enable leaders to execute without waiting for certainty.

CONVERSATION IS KEY

Over time, this approach has also shaped culture. “Culture is built conversation by conversation,” Mahindra has said, arguing that it cannot be imposed but emerges from how leaders behave when no one is watching.

That thinking found expression in the group’s “rise” philosophy. “Rise isn’t about Mahindra rising — it’s about

India leads OTT content spend growth in Asia-Pacific

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Indian content platforms are driving spends in the Asia-Pacific (APAC) region, as per data from Ampere Analysis, shared in a Content India Trends report. Offerings such as crime dramas and family content garnered a strong demand, particularly from the Middle East and the US.

Over the last five years, Indian media powerhouses and global streamers have driven the content spend trend, going from 8 per cent of \$20.4 billion in 2021 to an estimated 12 per cent of \$22 billion in 2026.

JioStar, Zee Entertainment and Sony India, commissioned the bulk of titles in 2025, the data showed.

ONLINE POWERHOUSE

JioStar led with around 140 commissioned titles while runner-up Zee commissioned around 80 titles in the year. Sony commissioned around 50 titles.

Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Egypt, the US and the Philippines were the top markets for such content, with scripted content dominating globally at 88 per cent.

Hannah Walsh, Principal Analyst, Ampere Analysis, speaking at the Content India Summit 2026, organized by Dish TV, said India had become a global content powerhouse, producing over 24,000 titles in January 2026, with 19,000 available internationally.

Taking a five-year outlook, Daoud Jackson, Senior Analyst, OMDIA, estimated online video in India to nearly double the revenue of traditional TV, becoming the main driver of growth in 2030. Jackson also noted how India produced a quarter of all YouTube videos globally in 2025.

